NO. 143 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SUNDAY 25 OCTOBER 2026 · THE SUNDAY EDITION



SEVEN SPRING TYPES, SEVEN HELLS, AND A HUNDRED THOUSAND LITRES A MINUTE (P21)

THE TRAVEL DESK

Japan's own site still sells the seven-day rail pass at the old price

THE ATELIER

Europe deleted the one number that compared vacuum cleaners, and never replaced it

THE RABBIT HOLE

The number stamped on the limb is not the draw weight you pull

Source: Wikimedia Commons. Umi Jigoku, Beppu, Oita. The carp streamers date the frame to early May; the pond looks like this year round.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 143

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THE SPINE: THE WRONG LAYER. Six desks this week found the same shape: the thing that was fixed was not the thing that was broken. A threshold deleted rather than improved; a bug one layer below the one everybody blamed; a label annulled and never replaced; a ban that moved nothing it aimed at; and, on p25, a planning law rewritten over a title nobody will lend against.

FROM THE DESK

"People will not look forward to posterity, who never look backward to their ancestors."

Edmund Burke, *Reflections on the Revolution in France*, **1790**[1]

The sentence after it is better still: inheritance furnishes "a sure principle of conservation, and a sure principle of transmission, without at all excluding a principle of improvement". Which is the papakāinga argument, written seventy-five years before a settler court dissolved exactly that (p25).

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 2-year[2]	4.69%	▼ 4bp wk
US 10-year[2]	5.00%	▼ 9bp wk
VWRA	$189.60	▼ 1.08% wk
USD/SGD	1.2785	▼ 0.05% wk
USD/JPY	156.80	▼ 0.77% wk
Brent	$116.72	▲ 3.14% day
Bitcoin	$81,086	▼ 0.51% wk

Gold is a band this week, not a point: US$3,994–4,008. Four venues, no agreement, one with the opposite sign (p14). Every other level read at source. Not advice.[2]

SIX NUMBERS FROM THIS ISSUE

¥50,000 against ¥53,000. The same seven-day Japan Rail Pass, two official channels, both read on the same page on the same day — and the online one is still last month's price (p19).

Five point one two tokens a second. The only measured home throughput anywhere for a model with fifteen published benchmark scores — and it came from a bug report, not the vendor (p8).

Ninety-seven, from forty critics. *You Can See Everything*'s Metacritic score, beside a Rotten Tomatoes ninety-eight drawn from a hundred and sixty-six. The same week, the same film, two panels differing fourfold (p11).

Five hundred motor hours. The European minimum a vacuum cleaner must meet. Miele claims a thousand; the commodity motor anyone can buy by part number claims fifteen hundred (p6).

Twenty-seven thousand titles, three and a quarter million owners. New Zealand's Māori freehold land — and the average block has gained eighteen owners since 2013 (p26).

Sixteen homes in five years. What Māori land has yielded in one of New Zealand's fastest-growing cities, in the five years before the law that was supposed to be the obstacle was repealed (p25).

SOURCES 1 Edmund Burke, *Reflections on the Revolution in France* (1790), read in the full text of Volume III of his collected works; the quoted sentence and the one following it are as printed, punctuation included. 2 Levels as at the close of Friday 23 October 2026, each read at source and set out with its own sourcing on p14, where the dollar index's weekly change is held and gold is printed as a band.

THE WORLD · HEBRON

Israel sealed Hebron and displaced two thousand Palestinians before Tuesday's election

Defence Minister Israel Katz says the displaced "will not be allowed to return" until the army finishes in the city; Hebron's mayor Yousef al-Ja'bari counts 2,200 forced out, and Israelis vote for 120 Knesset seats on 27 October.

Israel's army sealed Hebron on Saturday 24 October and began a closure of the occupied West Bank, a day after two soldiers were shot dead at a checkpoint outside the city. About two thousand people were emptied from their neighbourhoods, and they go to the polls, or do not, on Tuesday. Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu had ordered it within hours: "I have instructed the IDF and security forces to immediately impose a closure on the city of Hebron."[1]

The soldiers were Staff Sgt. Ron Yonatan Roytman and Sgt. Yuval Shai Svilem; two attackers were killed. By Saturday troops had raided at least fifteen areas of the West Bank, and the Palestinian Prisoners' Society counted about seventy arrests. Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich ordered demolitions to "create deterrence and exact a price"; Reuters saw bulldozers start work.[2]

The displacement figure is where the two accounts part. Katz, interviewed by Kan, said about two thousand had been displaced and would not be allowed back "until we finish dealing with all the Hamas issues in Hebron". Mayor al-Ja'bari counts 2,200, and Palestinian officials say another 2,500 face evacuation. The governorate holds roughly 800,000 people, 200,000 in the city.[3]

> ***"We will act to destroy this place, to change it completely."***

What makes the timing readable is the calendar. Netanyahu cancelled all Likud events on Friday, promised the Palestinian Authority a "big surprise" on Saturday without saying what, and said: "The IDF is ready to execute it and we will set the timing." On Saturday night a Tel Aviv rally's organisers claimed more than a hundred thousand people demanding a statutory inquiry into 7 October.[4]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Leads on the displacement itself: "Israel has imposed a lockdown and displaced thousands of Palestinians from their homes in Hebron." Correspondent Nour Odeh's framing is that Israeli politicians are trying to "capitalise" on the attack before 27 October.[5]

JERUSALEM — THE JERUSALEM POST

Leads on the checkpoint: five Israelis hit, two dead, under the headline that Netanyahu "blocks off travel". The quotation it carries is the threat rather than the consequence — "You have nowhere to hide." The displacement number does not appear. CGTN supplies a third framing, "biggest West Bank operation in decades before vote", but credits AFP.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT WOULD BREAK THE READING

B'Tselem says the plans amount to "collective punishment and acts that could constitute war crimes"; António Guterres says the closures "severely restrict Palestinians' freedom of movement, access to basic services and livelihoods". But the electoral reading is an inference, not a confession: Netanyahu's stated trigger is the killing, and he cancelled rallies rather than staged them. **If the closure lifts before Tuesday, the timing argument weakens.** One further caution — a report that Israel's High Court had halted the demolitions could not be confirmed in four reads of the Israeli liveblogs, and is not printed here as fact.[6]

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ATTACKS ON PALESTINIAN FARMERS, LAND AND OLIVE TREES COUNTED IN OCTOBER ALONE BY THE PALESTINIAN COLONIZATION AND WALL RESISTANCE COMMISSION, SEVENTEEN OF THEM ON THURSDAY[6]

SOURCES 1 The Jerusalem Post, 23 October 2026; France 24, 23 October, carrying Reuters and AFP material. 2 The Times of Israel liveblogs of 23 and 24 October for the names, the Smotrich order and the cordon; Al Jazeera, 23 October, for the arrest tallies. 3 Katz's Kan interview as carried in the Times of Israel liveblog of 24 October; Al Jazeera, 24 October, for the mayor's 2,200 and the governorate population. **The two figures are an Israeli minister's and a Palestinian mayor's, and both are printed.** 4 France 24 and Al Jazeera, both 24 October; rally attendance is the organisers' own claim. 5 Al Jazeera, 24 October; The Jerusalem Post, 23 October; CGTN Europe, 23 October, which credits AFP. **TASS and Global Times carried no West Bank item on their world fronts when read on Saturday.** 6 B'Tselem, Guterres and the farm-attack count via Al Jazeera, 24 October. **Reuters, the BBC and the Associated Press all refused this desk directly; their material is read through outlets that license it.**

THE WORLD · META IN NEW MEXICO

A New Mexico judge cut Meta's 219-billion-dollar penalty to 25 billion

Judge Francis J. Mathew attached fifteen per cent annual interest — about 10.3 million dollars a day — and gave no method for the reduction; Meta's 10-Q, filed the same week, says it has accrued for the loss and will appeal.

Judge Francis J. Mathew of New Mexico's First Judicial District Court filed a judgment at 10.51 on Wednesday 21 October ordering Meta Platforms to pay a civil penalty of twenty-five billion dollars for misleading Facebook users about privacy. A jury had found 43,899,720 violations of the state's Unfair Practices Act on 25 September; at five thousand dollars each that is **US$219,498,600,000**, which the judgment says "is reduced to the amount of $25,000,000,000.00".[1]

It gives no method for the reduction. What it gives is a rate: fifteen per cent a year "until paid in full", roughly 3.75 billion dollars a year, about 10.3 million a day. The judgment does not say whether that compounds, from what date it runs, or whether a bond is required. Meta's own quarterly filing confirms the order and says the company "intends to appeal".[1]

The penalty lands on a strange quarter. Revenue was 64.60 billion dollars, up twenty-six per cent; operating income fell thirty-seven per cent to 12.99 billion after a 9.89 billion charge for an August settlement with fifty-two attorneys general, from which New Mexico had opted out. Over nine months Meta spent 83.06 billion on property and equipment against 96.87 billion of operating cash.[2]

Then the subsequent-events note, which the market read harder than the fine. Meta has established a class of non-voting Class C stock, effective 19 January 2027, and declared one Class C share for every A and B share outstanding. The risk factors are unusually candid: Meta "expect[s] to use shares of the Class C common stock to conduct equity offerings", and warns the class "may trade at a discount" so more shares may be needed per raise.[2]

−6.7%

THE PHILADELPHIA SEMICONDUCTOR INDEX ON THURSDAY, ITS WORST DAY SINCE JUNE; META ITSELF FELL SEVEN PER CENT ON A QUARTER THAT BEAT[3]

THE CHATTER · HACKER NEWS, 697 POINTS

JohnMakin read it as a cost of doing business: two hundred billion "lawyered down to 25, on appeal I imagine much less". **advisedwang** corrected the thread's premise — it "was not damages, it was a statutory per-count penalty". **kube-system** supplied the sharpest reading of American privacy law: what was found illegal "wasn't Facebook's blatant disregard for privacy", only "the fact they lied about it".[4]

THE SCEPTIC · A CEILING, NOT A COST

Gil Luria of D.A. Davidson: Meta "is worth nearly $2 trillion and will likely continue to appeal these cases and drag them out". Meta's own counsel, Matt Nicholson, pressed the argument that will decide it: "The jury didn't make findings that any New Mexican heard or saw these statements, or was harmed by them." **And the filing is its own caution: Meta says it has accrued "an amount" and does not say how much, so twenty-five billion is a ceiling on the cash consequence, not a measure of it.**[5]

IN BRIEF

22 Oct · Coral. The IUCN published the first Red List of Coral Reef Ecosystems: of 127 reef ecoregions covering 188,362 square kilometres, **96 per cent are Critically Endangered** once future warming is modelled, 24 per cent on observed change alone. The Western Galápagos is already classed Collapsed, since the 1982–83 El Niño.[6]

25 Oct · Brazil. Voting today in a presidential runoff between Flávio Bolsonaro, who took about 47 per cent in the first round, and Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva on just over 45. A Quaest poll on 21 October had it 45 to 44.[6]

24 Oct · Hormuz, delta only. Iranian state television says Tehran has offered to reopen the strait if the United States lifts its blockade. **Headline read at source; the body was not.**[6]

SOURCES 1 Meta Platforms, Form 10-Q for the quarter ended 30 September 2026, Note 10, read in full at the Securities and Exchange Commission's own archive; PPC Land's read of the judgment itself, case D-101-CV-2021-00132, for the filing time, the reduced-from figure and the interest terms. The per-violation arithmetic is this desk's. 2 Same 10-Q, Item 2 and Notes 10 and 14. 3 Reuters via the Honolulu Star-Advertiser, 22 October 2026. 4 Hacker News thread 50184820, 21 October, 697 points, quoted verbatim; **Reddit refused for the eleventh issue**. 5 Luria and Lim via NBC News, 21 October; Nicholson at the 1 October hearing via PPC Land; the accrual language is Meta's own. 6 IUCN release, 22 October; The Korea Herald, 23 October; Al Jazeera, 23 October; TASS world front, 24 October. **The New Mexico Department of Justice's own release returned a 403, as did Courthouse News. Two items from a security roundup — a BBC el-Fasher investigation and two Nature Health heat-death papers — are not printed, because neither host could be reached.**

SINGAPORE · THE SEPTEMBER PRICE PRINT

Singapore's MAS reports core inflation at 2.0 per cent, electricity 8.7 dearer

The same table has private transport at 7.1 per cent. Residents surveyed for SMU's inflation index in September expect 3.4 per cent over the coming year — some way above the number the Government printed on Friday.

The Monetary Authority of Singapore and the Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry reported on Friday 23 October that MAS Core Inflation eased to 2.0 per cent year on year in September, from 2.2 in August, with headline CPI at 2.2 from 2.3. Month on month, core rose 0.1 per cent and the all-items index 0.2. The easing is in services, down from 2.0 to 1.7, and in retail goods, from 1.8 to 1.2.[1]

The line a household actually feels is further down the table, and it is a cliff rather than a trend. Electricity and gas have run **8.7 per cent** above a year earlier for three straight months. The index sat at 93.666 in June and 103.267 in July — a jump of more than ten per cent in a single month. The release says why: the third-quarter regulated tariff carries through the spike in global energy prices from April to mid-June.[1]

Which is where the weights matter, and where the easing and the grumbling stop contradicting each other. Electricity and gas carry **198 points of the ten-thousand-point basket**; accommodation carries 2,656, services 3,173. An 8.7 per cent rise in the one you notice monthly can coexist with a 2.2 per cent headline because the index is not weighted by salience. This desk recomputed the headline from the statistics department's own table and got 2.20.[2]

Cars priced on Wednesday. At the second October tender, Category A rose S$2,003 to **S$132,004**, the second-highest on record, overtaking Category B at S$131,901 for the fourth time this year. The Land Transport Authority noted an upcoming car exhibition "which may lead to elevated demand" and urged buyers to be prudent; its consultation on merging the two categories closes on 2 November.[3]

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OF THE BASKET'S TEN THOUSAND POINTS SIT IN ELECTRICITY AND GAS. ACCOMMODATION CARRIES 2,656 — SO THE PRICE RISING FASTEST IS THE ONE WITH LEAST WEIGHT IN THE NUMBER[1]

THE MEASURED READ · WHAT RESIDENTS EXPECT

Not a forum this week but a survey, which is better. The 61st DBS-SKBI Singapore Index of Inflation Expectations, fielded among **510 residents from 11 to 21 September** and released on 20 October, puts one-year-ahead headline expectations at **3.4 per cent** and one-year core at **3.6**, up from 3.4. Five-year core rose to **4.2** from 3.8. Professor Hong Zhang, who directs the institute: "The stronger rise in longer-term core inflation expectations is worth watching."[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT WOULD UNDO THE EASING

The release argues against itself, usefully. It says "the risks to inflation remain tilted to the upside", and names among them that inflation could stay elevated "if spillovers from the AI-related boom broaden and unit labour costs rise more rapidly" — the same build-out repriced on Wall Street on Thursday (p4). **If the next regulated tariff moves, or car prices resume climbing, both the 2.0 core and the full-year forecast go.** Electricity's 8.7 drops out of the index mechanically in July 2027 whatever prices do.[5]

ALSO THIS WEEK

21–22 Oct · A referral that never happened. Neo Jia Ming, 27, was jailed sixteen years and Chloe Gan Ci Xuan, 23, fifteen years and three months over the death of their eight-month-old son in September 2024. The Ministry of Social and Family Development said on Thursday the boy had not been referred to its Protective Service or any social service agency before he died; an independent review panel "highlighted the need for professionals to better recognise and respond to concerns involving infants".[6]

SOURCES 1 Monetary Authority of Singapore and Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry, "Consumer Price Developments in September 2026", 23 October 2026, read in full as published; Tables A.1 and A.2 for the component rates, the basket weights and the July index level, and footnote 1 of that release for the tariff explanation. 2 Singapore Department of Statistics, table M213751, Consumer Price Index 2024 as base year, monthly, last updated 23 October 2026 and queried directly; the recomputation is this desk's arithmetic from the published index levels. **SingStat's own highlights page and release PDF both returned 403; the table interface served normally.** 3 Second October certificate tender, closed 21 October, via Little Big Reddot and Motorist, both read at source. **Category C is given as S$92,200 by one and S$92,900 by the other; S$92,200 is the figure consistent with the stated move, and neither is printed above.** 4 Singapore Management University, 61st DBS-SKBI Singapore Index of Inflation Expectations, released 20 October 2026. 5 The quoted risk language is the release's own. A widely-reported claim that the 2.0 print undershot a 2.3 per cent market consensus could not be read at source and is **not** asserted here. 6 The Straits Times via Asia News Network, 22 October 2026, for the ministry's statement; the ministry's own media room returned an empty body. METI newsroom, 14 October 2026. **Reddit, HardwareZone, SGCarMart, MyCarForum and SingaporeExpats all refused this desk; SGTalk failed to resolve. The survey above stands in place of forum sentiment, and is labelled as a survey.**

THE ATELIER · VACUUM CLEANERS

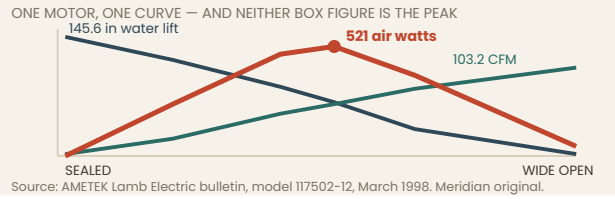
In 2019 Europe annulled its vacuum energy label and published no replacement

Dyson brought the case and the General Court struck down Regulation 665/2013 on 8 November 2018, retroactively. What survives is a floor — 500 motor hours, 900 watts, one per cent re-emission — and no number that compares one machine with another.

Start with the mechanism. Suction is two numbers, not one, at opposite ends of the same curve: **water lift** is measured at a sealed orifice, where airflow is zero, and **airflow** wide open, where there is almost no lift. Air watts are their product, so a box figure is quoted at whichever end flatters the machine. An AMETEK Lamb unit pulls **145.6 inches of water sealed and moves nothing at all**; wide open it moves **103.2 cubic feet a minute**. Peak power is neither.[1]

ASTM's own method says as much: the results "do not indicate the actual air power present during the cleaning process." Europe once published a comparable number and then stopped. Dyson argued that testing with an empty receptacle flattered bagged machines, whose pores clog in use; the General Court agreed on 8 November 2018, and because the calculation could not be severed, the whole regulation fell. From 18 January 2019 it was void **"as if it had never existed"**, and nothing has replaced it.[2]

What survives is a floor, not a ladder: since 2017 a vacuum sold in the EU must draw under **900 watts**, lift 75 per cent of test dust from carpet and 98 from hard floor, re-emit under **one per cent**, and run its motor **500 hours**. Re-emission is the figure to demand, because it is a whole-appliance test: an H14 element behind a leaking gasket fails it, and a lesser element in a sealed body passes.[3]



Water lift falls as airflow rises; air power peaks in the middle, at an orifice no catalogue quotes.[2]

THE CHATTER · HARDER ON ITS GRAILS THAN ANY ADVERTISER

There is no agreed endgame: VacuumLand splits between pre-1990s Kirbys, vintage Electrolux canisters and current Mieles, each with a detractor in the same thread. On Miele, "lets be honest mieles latest offerings do not have the same build quality as their previous models" — though "no vacuum on the market filters better than a Miele". On SEBO, "materials and build quality are vastly better", answered by "cheap plastic parts start falling off it". **Quoted from the search index; the forum 403s every direct read.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE MONEY STOPS WORKING

The curve flattens at about **£420**, roughly S$600: a sealed bagged body, a *separate* brush motor so agitation stops stealing airflow, and five years of cover. Above that nothing published improves, because there is nothing published to improve against. **Cordless is the step that is not an upgrade:** SEBO's own A1 Pro costs £439 against the corded Felix's £419.90, carries **two years instead of five** and excludes battery run-time. One number runs the other way: the EU demands **500 motor hours**, Miele claims a thousand, and AMETEK's catalogue claims **1,500-plus** for a part anyone can order. **And here, SEBO lists eighteen partner markets and Singapore is not one of them**; Numatic's local distributor carries the commercial range only, and Best Denki's Miele page lists one vacuum, bagless and out of stock.[5]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Table linen & napkins — damask, hemstitch, and the mills still weaving flax.

Hand planes & chisels — infill against Bailey, and the sharpening economy behind both.

Mosquito nets — denier, mesh count, and a tropical object with a real standard.

SOURCES 1 ASTM F558-21's significance-and-use clause, read at the publisher's page; AMETEK Lamb Electric product bulletin, model 117502-12, March 1998, read in full. 2 Court of Justice of the European Union, Press Release 168/18, Case T-544/13 RENV, 8 November 2018; Official Journal C 96/35 of 13 March 2019 for the retroactive effect; the European Commission's own product page confirms these products "no longer have an energy label". 3 Commission Regulation (EU) 666/2013, Annex I, read in the UK retained-law reproduction, **EUR-Lex having returned a 202**; EN 1822 classes from two filter makers' published tables. 4 VacuumLand threads named in this desk's notes, **quoted from the search index because the forum returned a Cloudflare 403 to every direct fetch; Reddit refused for the eleventh issue**. 5 SEBO's own guarantee and price pages and IEC 60312-1's published scope. **Miele's thousand-hour figure is Miele's own claim, attributed and not read at source — every Miele domain returned a 403, as did the Internet Archive.** 6 SEBO's partner list, Numatic's distributor locator, Best Denki and Harvey Norman Singapore, read 24 October 2026. **Dyson's entire estate refused this desk, and RTINGS has moved its measurements behind a paywall.**

TECHNOLOGY · THE TREASURY RULE

Treasury proposes scrapping its ten-to-the-twenty-fifth test for AI investment bans

The 38-page notice, filed for public inspection at 8.45am on Friday and publishing Monday as 91 FR 67396, would forbid any American funding of "any SI system" in six countries. Comments close 7 December.

The Treasury's Office of Investment Security filed a proposed rule in Washington at 8.45 on Friday 23 October that would forbid Americans from funding the development of **any** "super intelligence system" in China, Russia, Iran, North Korea, Cuba or Venezuela. In doing so it abandons the only number the programme has: the **ten-to-the-twenty-fifth computational-operation** training threshold.[1]

The current rule is an engineer's tripwire. Under section 850.224 a system is caught above that count, or if built for military, intelligence or mass-surveillance use. Above the line, prohibited; below it, you notify and move on. That worked while pre-training compute was a usable proxy for capability.[2]

Treasury says in its own preamble that it no longer is: **"no single measure, benchmark, or threshold is currently sufficient to distinguish advanced models."** It names the reasons — synthetic data, architectural efficiency, post-training technique, inference-time compute. A sparse model that activates twenty-three billion of four hundred and twenty-eight billion parameters breaks the proxy by construction (p8).[3]

> *"No single measure, benchmark, or threshold is currently sufficient to distinguish advanced models."*

For an investor that inverts the burden. Under the threshold you had to measure the target; under the proposal you need only establish that it builds models from data, which describes most of the Chinese software industry — and the notification valve is gone, because super intelligence becomes prohibited-only. Treasury presents the loss of measurability as the point.[4]

0.0026 µm²

THE DRAM CELL AREA THE SAME DOCUMENT SPECIFIES TO FOUR DECIMAL PLACES, BESIDE 128 NAND LAYERS, 3,000 THROUGH-SILICON VIAS AND A SUPERCOMPUTER ENVELOPE GIVEN TO THE CUBIC FOOT. FOR SI SYSTEMS: NO NUMBER AT ALL[5]

THE CHATTER · NOBODY SAW THIS COMING

Hacker News carried no thread at all on the Treasury notice. It had one on the rename four weeks earlier, and the mood was derision. **k310**: "Food items that yesterday contained ARTIFICIAL ingredients, today have SUPERIOR ingredients." **croes** reached for Orwell. Nobody in eight comments guessed the relabel would reappear inside an investment prohibition a month later.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · A RULE THAT DECLINES TO MEASURE

Two practitioners quoted by the Associated Press keep it procedural: Ryan Majerus of King & Spalding calls it "just the first step in a fairly long process", and Jason Chipman of WilmerHale says it "will require more substantial compliance programs". **Both are relayed through a secondary outlet and were not read at the wire.** The harder observation is on the page: the proposal publishes **no threshold, no parameter count, no benchmark and no capability test**. A document that specifies a memory cell to four decimal places and declines to specify a model is making a choice.[5]

WHAT IT MEANS HERE

The reach includes Singapore. A "US person" is any citizen or lawful permanent resident, wherever resident. De minimis is **US$50,000** over twelve months; the limited-partner exception covers committed capital to **US$2 million** in a non-US fund. Index funds and ETFs are excepted, and the knowledge standard is constructive.[7]

SOURCES 1 Federal Register public-inspection listing for 23 October 2026, document 2026-21786, filed 08:45 Eastern; publishing 26 October at 91 FR 67396–67433, RIN 1505-AC94. 2 Title 31 CFR 850.224, read at Cornell's Legal Information Institute. 3 The proposed rule's preamble, read in full text. 4 Executive Order 14434, signed 29 September 2026, published 2 October at 91 FR 63129; section 3(a) defines the term by reference to 15 U.S.C. 9401(3). 5 Technical parameters from the rule's own text; the absence of any SI parameter is this desk's reading. 6 Hacker News item 49901874, 29 September, eight comments, quoted verbatim; **Reddit refused for the eleventh issue**. 7 Treasury's own COINS Act fact sheet, 22 October 2026. **The Federal Register and eCFR websites both redirect to an unblock gateway for this sandbox; the JSON and full-text endpoints served normally. No Chinese, Russian or Singaporean official reaction had been published in the window.**

THE HOME LAB · MINIMAX M3.1 FLASH

MiniMax opened its 428B M3.1 Flash weights and broke local inference

Within hours the llama.cpp runtime was emitting gibberish, because MiniMax's graph file never handed it the per-expert quantisation scales. A maintainer merged the nine-tensor fix on Saturday; the only measured home throughput anywhere is 5.12 tokens a second.

MiniMax published open weights for M3.1 Flash on Hugging Face on Friday 23 October, four days after launching the model's API. Within hours a user filing as MOUNTAIN0724 opened llama.cpp issue 31063. The model loaded without error or warning. Prompted with "The capital of France is", it returned unrelated tokens in four scripts — at every quantisation, with and without GPU offload, and entirely on CPU.[1]

The cause is worth understanding, because the failure mode is one you will meet again. M3.1 Flash is natively mixed-precision: NVFP4 for the routed experts, MXFP8 for the dense weights, which is why 428 billion parameters occupy 252GB. NVFP4 stores a weight as a four-bit mantissa plus a per-block exponent, and a per-tensor **global scale** restores the range.[2]

The loader read those scales off disk correctly. The model's own graph file never passed them down: the scale arguments sit at the end of the expert-FFN call and default to null. Nine scale tensors stayed at their defaults, and every expert weight came out **roughly fifteen thousand times too large**.[3]

In a dense model that overflows and you know. In a sparse mixture of experts it does something worse: it stays finite. Attention and the prediction head were scaled properly, so the residual stream remained valid at every layer and merely drowned. No assertion, no warning, no NaN — a model that loads, runs at plausible speed and writes fluent nonsense. The fix merged a day later.[3]

If a mixed-precision model loads clean and writes fluent nonsense, suspect a dropped scale before you suspect your quant.

Whether you can run it at all is a separate problem. Unsloth's four GGUF builds are **175, 194, 249 and 259 gigabytes**. None fits a 128GB machine, and the card publishes no memory guidance at all. The community shipped sub-three-bit formats inside forty-eight hours; nobody has measured one.[4]

5.12 tok/s

DECODE, 3.59 PREFILL, AT Q2_K ON A RYZEN 7 9700X WITH A 32GB RTX 5090 AND 128GB OF SYSTEM MEMORY. THE ONLY MEASURED HOME FIGURE FOR THIS MODEL ANYWHERE — AND IT CAME FROM THE BUG REPORT, NOT THE VENDOR[1]

THE CHATTER · THE HARDWARE ARGUMENT

The launch thread ran to 517 points and had the question settled before the weights landed. **Tepix** did the arithmetic: "At 428B it can still fit on 2x 128GB machines at 4bpw" — true only across two boxes, since the four-bit build is 249GB. **trilogic** set the bar at "at least 13 tps in consumer hardware"; **mickeyp** went harder — "13 TPS is unusable for agentic coding". Against the measured 5.12, the thread had answered itself.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · FIFTEEN SCORES, NO VRAM FIGURE

jakswa cites Epoch's audit of DeepSWE — "We found issues in at least 23 out of 113 tasks" — the benchmark MiniMax leads with, at 73.7. **DCKing**: "This model seems to be pretty benchmaxed". **eskibars** found it "far underperforms relative to GLM 5.3" on security work, against a card claiming 82.2 on CyberGym. **And it is not open source:** the licence grants non-commercial use only.[6]

SOURCES 1 llama.cpp issue 31063, filed 23 October 2026, read at source, including the reporter's hardware and throughput. 2 The MiniMax model card and file listing: 428 billion parameters, 23 billion active, one-million-token context, 48 shards totalling 252GB. **The card's prose says 428B while the repository metadata reads 220B; that is a packing artefact, and no reconciliation is asserted.** 3 Pull request 31097, one commit, nine scale tensors at three call sites, merged 24 October; the magnitude figure is the one stated there. 4 Unsloth's GGUF repository; **the community quantisation sizes are parameter-field figures, not verified file bytes**. 5 Hacker News item 50154540, 19 October, quoted verbatim; **Reddit refused for the eleventh issue**. 6 Same thread; licence text read in the repository. Artificial Analysis measures the reasoning variant at 95.6 tokens a second against a claimed two hundred, and **still lists the model as proprietary. No measured VRAM figure exists from any source.**

THE KIT · GRADO SIGNATURE S150

Grado opened pre-orders on Thursday for the US$295 Signature S150

The hand-assembled Brooklyn open-back runs a new 44mm paper-composite driver at 38 ohms and 220 grams, and undercuts the next Signature model by seventy per cent. Grado's own store lists it as "Pre Order" and "Sold out" at once.

Grado Labs opened pre-orders in Brooklyn on Thursday 22 October for the Signature S150 at US$295, shipping expected early November and UK availability late in the month. It is the least expensive open-back the company has ever put in its high-end Signature Line, and the ladder above it is steep: HP100 SE at US$2,495, S950 at US$2,195, S750 at US$1,695, S550 at US$995. The S150 undercuts the model directly above it by about seventy per cent.[1]

The engineering question is what that costs. Grado took the 52mm diaphragm of the HP100 SE down to **44mm** — roughly twenty-eight per cent less radiating area — and held sensitivity at 104dB per milliwatt by dropping nominal impedance to **38 ohms**. That is the trade. A 38-ohm load draws more current at the same voltage, and it is low enough that the source's output impedance starts to matter: on a cheap dongle with two ohms or more you will measurably shift the response. The optional 4.4mm and four-pin balanced terminations quietly concede the point.[2]

The diaphragm is paper composite, which buys high internal damping — breakup modes die rather than ring — at the price of unit-to-unit variation. Which is why the one number on the page that really earns its ink is not the frequency response but the **0.05dB driver matching**: it says the pairs are hand-matched. The rest of the published spec is 16Hz to 34kHz, under 0.3 per cent distortion at 100dB, and 220 grams.[1]

New at this price is a detachable cable, dual 3.5mm at the earcups, with three source terminations. The chamber is moulded ABS, the headband padded leather over a steel tension band, the cushions Grado's F pads. It is an on-ear, so pad choice rather than clamp governs a long session.[1]

0.05 dB

THE PUBLISHED DRIVER-MATCHING TOLERANCE — THE ONLY FIGURE ON THE PAGE THAT IS A MEASUREMENT OF THIS PAIR RATHER THAN A CLAIM ABOUT THE MODEL[1]

THE CHATTER · THE SILENCE IS THE FINDING

There is none, and that is reportable. Three days after pre-orders opened, Head-Fi served a bot-verification wall rather than a thread; Audio Science Review's forum search returns "No results found", so no measurement thread exists; Hacker News has nothing; Reddit refused for the eleventh issue. The only attributed owner voice anywhere is a reader comment on Ecoustics dated 23 October, reporting that no dealer in the EU stocks the Signature Bronze cable — which squares with Grado's own "Sold out" banner.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · TRICKLE-DOWN IS AN ASSUMPTION

Ian White at Ecoustics wrote the only sceptical launch piece, and declines the obvious inference: it is **"premature to assume the S150 delivers the same level of refinement"** as the HP100 SE and S950 merely because it borrows their design ideas. He puts a number on the competition — FiiO's FT3 at US$299 fields a **60mm** driver against the S150's 44 — and notes that no independent measurements exist. MajorHiFi puts it plainly: the sound characteristics "remain the company's claims".[4]

STILL ON THE SHELF

Technics EAH-A1000 — the 2026 flagship noise-cancelling over-ear, newly developed 40mm magnetic-fluid drivers, about US$450, with a Japanese on-sale date reported as 19 November. **Held:** the MSRP and both dates are single-sourced through search summaries; no Technics newsroom page could be reached.[5]

Schiit Bifrost 3 — US$699 in black, US$729 in silver, landing alongside the Mani 3 phono stage at US$149. Both read in the same trade round-up, updated 23 October.[5]

SOURCES 1 Grado Labs' own Signature S150 product page and Signature Line collection page, read 24 October 2026: price, full specification, cable options, cushion compatibility and the five-model ladder. **The product page shows a "Pre Order" button above a price block reading "Sold out", and publishes no ship date, no box contents, no cable conductor material and no warranty terms; every model in the Signature Line reads "Sold out" on the collection page.** 2 Driver diameter and impedance from the same page; the source-impedance consequence is this desk's reading of the published figures, not a measurement. 3 Head-Fi, Audio Science Review, Hacker News and Reddit all checked on 24 October with the results described; the Ecoustics reader comment is dated 23 October. 4 Ian White, Ecoustics, Grado Signature S150, read at source; MajorHiFi, 22 October 2026, which carries the full specification table and the press images. 5 Gear Patrol's hi-fi round-up, published and updated 23 October 2026. **No Singapore price exists for any Signature model: Sweelee, Grado's listed local retailer, carries the Prestige series only, and no local distributor lists the line. A nominal conversion at 1.30 puts US$295 near S$385 before tax and shipping, and that is this desk's arithmetic, not a price.**

THE GOOD LIFE · TOLEDANO & CHAN

Toledano & Chan launched the b/1 Dazzle on Saturday at US$7,700

The New York micro-brand cut dazzle camouflage into Grade 5 titanium and kept the Sellita SW100 that already powers its US$6,300 standard b/1 — 188 plain-dial pieces, plus twelve diamond-set Double Dazzles at US$9,700.

Toledano & Chan opened sales of the b/1 Dazzle on Saturday 24 October: two hundred small brutalist titanium watches whose engraved pattern runs unbroken across dial, case and bracelet. The split is 188 plain-dial pieces at **US$7,700** and twelve pavé-set Double Dazzles at **US$9,700**, carrying roughly 350 diamonds.[1]

The finish is the product, in three operations: the pattern is CNC-engraved into Grade 5 titanium, frosted with diamond dust, then hand-brushed. Because all three run across every surface at once, the lines cross the gap between case and bracelet link without a break. The reference is naval dazzle camouflage — the scheme that never tried to hide a ship, only to make its heading hard to read.[2]

On a watch the trick works in reverse. The b/1 case is an unusual shape — about 32mm across, nine to ten millimetres thick depending where you measure, destro, crown on the left, a faceted sapphire standing proud of the case like a cut stone. The whole appeal of the standard model is that silhouette, and disruption painted across it hides the one thing worth looking at.[3]

> *"A high fashion bracelet with a barely legible three-hundred-dollar movement in it."*

Inside is a **Sellita SW100**, derived from the ETA 2671: 25 jewels, 28,800 vibrations an hour, about 42 hours of reserve, no chronometer certification. It is the calibre already fitted to the standard b/1, which the brand sells at **US$6,300**. The Dazzle asks **US$1,400 more — twenty-two per cent — for surface work alone**.[4]

Then there is what is not published. No Singapore price, no local dealer, no manufacturer spec sheet — and four outlets give four sets of dimensions, one openly estimating. On Saturday the maker's own Dazzle page still displayed US$6,300, the standard price, against the US$7,700 everyone else quotes.[5]

US$1,400

THE PREMIUM OVER THE STANDARD B/1 FOR ENGRAVING, FROSTING AND BRUSHING. SAME SELLITA SW100, SAME CASE, SAME FIVE ATMOSPHERES[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE COMMENTERS SAID

No forum thread had formed, so the honest record is the comment file under Fratello's introduction — hostile, for a release this hyped. **Davkis11**: "a high fashion bracelet with a barely legible $300 movement in it". **Jay_Dee** put the design objection best — it takes a watch "whose shape is everything" and disguises it with a pattern that hides that shape. Dissenting, **xbarx1**: "Modern art for the wrist."[6]

THE SCEPTIC · THE HOUSE CRITIC DECLINES

The sharpest dissent sits above the comments. Fratello's own writer will not endorse the watch he is introducing: the look "isn't totally to my taste", and he would not rank it among his favourite b/1 releases. Hodinkee Australia notes the Double Dazzle's diamonds "contradict the concept of concealment" — which is a polite way of saying the camouflage argument stops at the price list.[6]

STILL ON THE SHELF

Naim Mu-so Utopia — show debut at the Paris Audio Video Show, 23–24 October: fifteen Focal drivers, 720 watts, and, rare here, published numbers — 30Hz–20kHz ±3dB, 109dB peak at a metre. US$6,500 from January 2027, though **Naim's own page carries neither price nor date**.[7]

MING 57.05 "Comet" — a world-timer on this week's tracker at about CHF 6,950. **Held:** MING's product page returns a 404.[7]

SOURCES 1 Prices are US dollars before tax, read 24 October 2026 at Worn & Wound, Collective Horology and Time+Tide; **Toledano & Chan publishes no Singapore-dollar price**. 2 Finish sequence and pattern from Fratello Watches and Hodinkee Australia, 24 October. 3 Case geometry as those two describe it; see note 5. 4 The Sellita SW100 is an ETA 2671 derivative and the calibre in every b/1; the US$6,300 standard price is from the maker's own page, and the premium is this desk's arithmetic. 5 **Dimensions are disputed and there is no manufacturer spec sheet**: 32 × 31.5 × 9.1–10.4mm at two outlets, 32 × 30.6 at 12.3mm thick at a third, ~33.5 × 32 at a fourth which says it is estimating. The maker's own page displayed US$6,300 when read; unresolved at press time. 6 Comments quoted verbatim, original spelling preserved, from the Fratello thread; **Reddit refused for the eleventh issue**. 7 Naim's figures are its own; price and date are from the press release. **Audio Science Review returned an empty search and AVForums a 403, so no independent measurement exists.**

SCREEN & SOUND · YOU CAN SEE EVERYTHING

A24's You Can See Everything holds second place with 31.8 million dollars

Nathan Fielder and Lance Oppenheim's 174-minute film scores 98 per cent on 166 reviews and 97 on Metacritic from just 40 — while Warner Bros.' Clayface opened above it on Friday with 10.4 million.

A24's *You Can See Everything*, directed by Nathan Fielder and Lance Oppenheim, took **US$6,146,325** across 2,655 North American theatres on Friday 23 October, lifting its domestic total to **US$31,791,801** in its second week of wide release. It opened on 16 October and runs two hours and fifty-four minutes. Above it on Friday, on its opening day, sat Warner Bros. and DC Studios' *Clayface*, with **US$10,400,000** on 3,458 screens.[1]

The aggregate scores are where the week's real argument sits, and the argument is about sample size. *You Can See Everything* carries **98 per cent on Rotten Tomatoes from 166 critics** and **97 on Metacritic from 40**. The two panels differ by a factor of four, and a 97 drawn from forty reviewers is a far more fragile number than it looks.[2]

Clayface makes the same point from the other side. It reads **75 per cent fresh on Rotten Tomatoes from 155 critics** and **59, "mixed or average", on Metacritic from 44** — the same film, two scales, one verdict apiece. Audiences are elsewhere again, at 94 per cent on the Rotten Tomatoes popcorn meter. James Watkins directs; the consensus line calls it a film that "takes time to get going until it eventually morphs into an icky and satisfying revenge thriller".[2]

In music, Fontaines D.C. entered at number one on the Official Albums Chart for the week of 23 October with *Dopamine Chamber*, their second UK chart-topper and their fifth album, produced by James Ford and released on 16 October. It went to number one in seven territories, second in four — and **fifty-first on Japan's Oricon chart**, which is a gap worth noticing.[3]

97 : 40

THE METASCORE FOR *YOU CAN SEE EVERYTHING*, AND THE NUMBER OF CRITICS IT RESTS ON. ITS ROTTEN TOMATOES 98 RESTS ON 166 — FOUR TIMES THE PANEL FOR A NUMBER A POINT LOWER[2]

THE CHATTER · THE TRACKERS GOT FRIDAY WRONG

BoxOfficeReport, posting before the weekend on 23 October, had *You Can See Everything* first at US$24.5m and *Clayface* second at US$24.0m. Boxoffice Pro had framed it as a close race and put *Clayface* in a US$15m–20m weekend range. Friday's actuals put *Clayface* ahead and above its own pace. **Reddit refused for the eleventh issue running**, so no r/movies read appears; one widely-shared social claim that *You Can See Everything* is "sold out in a lot of theaters" carries no named source and is not printed as fact.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE WEEKEND DOES NOT EXIST YET

Box Office Mojo had posted no totals for the 23–25 October weekend when this page closed; the last completed weekend on its chart is 16–18 October, with a top-ten gross of US$91,520,374. Friday's US$10.4m for *Clayface* is a studio estimate, as all first-day figures are, and the film's release page on Mojo returns a 404, so it has **no published budget, no international gross and no opening-weekend figure**. And the two sources that agree on Friday's numbers to the dollar, Box Office Mojo and The Numbers, **both license the same upstream data**, so their agreement is not corroboration.[5]

ALSO THIS WEEK

The BFI London Film Festival closed its seventieth edition on 18 October, giving Best Film to Sergei Loznitsa's *Imperium* — a documentary taking the main competition prize. The Sutherland Award for a first feature went to Sompot Chidgasornpongse's *9 Temples to Heaven*, and the Grierson documentary award to Asmahan Bkerat's *Concrete Land*.[6]

Street Fighter has reached **US$40,683,634** domestic through Friday, on 3,575 screens — a cumulative update on the opening this desk ran three issues ago, not a new peg.[1]

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's daily chart for 23 October 2026, read at source, with The Numbers reproducing the same five figures. 2 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic, both read at source on 24 October 2026; critic counts are quoted beside every score deliberately. 3 The Official Charts Company's albums chart for 23–29 October 2026, read at source. **No first-week sales or streaming figure has been published anywhere readable, so none is printed; the album's Metacritic score of 85 from twenty reviews is taken second-hand, Metacritic's music pages having refused this desk with a 403.** 4 BoxOfficeReport's own pre-weekend post of 23 October and Boxoffice Pro's weekend preview. 5 Box Office Mojo's weekend index and the 404 on its *Clayface* release page, both checked 24 October. 6 The festival's winners, verified through a news aggregator and a cinematography trade report: **Deadline was reachable only at one remove and Screen Daily returned a 405.**

THE FAMILY DESK · THE MELBOURNE COHORT

A Melbourne cohort ties two hours of social media at twelve to depression

The Melbourne Child to Adult Transition Study followed 1,195 Australian children from a mean age of nine to nearly nineteen. For girls at twelve and thirteen the risk difference is 10.8 per hundred — with a confidence interval running from 2.7 to 18.9.

Nandita Vijayakumar and eleven colleagues published findings from the Melbourne Child to Adult Transition Study in the *Medical Journal of Australia* on 11 June, following 1,195 Australian children recruited in Grade 3 in 2012 through eleven waves. The exposure is self-reported daily social-media use in three bands, and the outcome is measured at the *following* wave. The reason it matters here is the age: the fourth wave has a mean age of **11.9 years**.[1]

Across all adolescents, more than two hours against under one carried a relative risk of **1.29 (95% CI 1.12 to 1.49)** for high depressive symptoms a year later. In the early-adolescent window, at a mean age of twelve to thirteen, the estimates are larger: girls **RR 1.72 (1.22 to 2.43)**, a risk difference of **10.8 per hundred (2.7 to 18.9)**; boys **RR 2.18 (1.32 to 3.59)**. The authors say the risks were greatest in early adolescence.[1]

Both intervals are wide, and the boys' lower bound sits at 0.7 per hundred, which is close to nothing. The authors' own limitations matter more than usual. They measured **duration only** — no split between active and passive use, no content, no cyberbullying. Exposure and outcome were both self-reported. The top band had to be capped at two hours, and **"no use" could not be separated from low use**, which they say limits conclusions about age-based restrictions.[1]

A second cohort measures the same age from the other end. Parker and colleagues followed 9,474 children in the American ABCD study from ages nine and ten to twelve and thirteen, and found screen-time trajectories associated with symptoms at the later point — depression β 2.94 (2.36 to 3.63) for the steadily increasing group. The authors describe the overall effects as small. And inside the same paper, one *social-media* trajectory was associated with **less** anxiety, β −0.30. The picture is not monotone.[2]

13.5 ± 2.2

THE MEAN AGE OF THE HUNDRED-THOUSAND-ADOLESCENT AUSTRALIAN WELLBEING STUDY THIS DESK IS *NOT* LEADING ON. A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD SITS 0.7 STANDARD DEVIATIONS BELOW IT, AT THE YOUNGEST EDGE OF ITS HEADLINE BAND[3]

THE LOCAL BASELINE · AND WHERE THE STEP UP SITS

Singapore's own figure is the Youth Epidemiology and Resilience study: 3,336 students aged 11 to 18, mean age 14, with weighted self-reported prevalence in the clinical range of **37.3 per cent internalising**. Its age bands start at 11–12, and that band is the **reference group** — so twelve-year-olds are the baseline, not the risk group. Measured against them, the 13–14 band showed affective problems at **OR 1.6 (1.1 to 2.1)**, with anxiety, somatic and conduct outcomes not significant. **The measured step up is just ahead of her.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · DON'T BE ALARMIST

Candice Odgers of the University of California, Irvine, quoted in a September review of the field: **"Hundreds of researchers, myself included, have searched for the kind of large effects suggested by Haidt. Our efforts have produced a mix of no, small and mixed associations."** The numbers behind her: Orben and Przybylski, testing some twenty thousand specifications, found an association explaining **at most 0.4 per cent** of variation in wellbeing, with bullying 4.3 times more strongly associated. A 2025 meta-analysis of 79 effect sizes pooled to **r = 0.061**.[5]

GENERAL GUIDANCE, NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

Every figure on these two pages is an association in a population, printed with its cohort's own mean age beside it. **None of these studies measured this child**, and the largest of them were built on adolescents older than she is. Questions about sleep, mood, puberty or anxiety belong with a doctor.

SOURCES 1 N. Vijayakumar and colleagues, "The Effects of Social Media on Adolescent Mental Health: Findings From a Population-Based Cohort Study in Australia", *Medical Journal of Australia* 224(6):e70220, 11 June 2026, doi 10.5694/mja2.70220; n = 1,195, wave-one mean age 9.0, wave-eleven mean 18.9, exposure measured from a mean age of 11.9. Read through the National Library of Medicine. 2 M. A. Parker and colleagues, *BMC Public Health* 2025;26:262, doi 10.1186/s12889-025-25956-3; n = 9,474, outcomes at ages 12–13. **The paper reports a median baseline age of 9.92 and no mean age, and this desk is saying so rather than supplying one.** 3 B. Singh and colleagues, *JAMA Pediatrics* 180(3):288–297, published 12 January 2026, doi 10.1001/jamapediatrics.2025.5619; n = 100,991, mean age 13.5 (SD 2.2), **no age range stated**. 4 J. C. M. Wong and colleagues, *Frontiers in Psychiatry* 15:1454484 (2024), doi 10.3389/fpsyt.2024.1454484; **the prevalences carry no confidence intervals in the paper, and none is invented here.** 5 L. Forcum, J. Morris and B. Sperry, "The Forbidden Feed", International Center for Law & Economics, 15 September 2026, read at source, including the Odgers quotation and the Orben, Przybylski, Ferguson and Parry figures it cites. **Reddit refused this desk for the eleventh issue, so no parenting-forum sentiment is reported.**

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE DUTCH PHONE BAN

In Dutch secondary schools, full phone bans matched partial bans on wellbeing

The 1,398-student Dutch sample also showed weaker student–teacher connectedness under full bans — boys β −0.23 — published on 7 January, the month Singapore extended its own restriction to the whole school day.

Elien Vanluydt and seven co-authors compared nine partial-ban and fifteen full-ban Dutch secondary schools in the *Journal of Youth and Adolescence* on 7 January, across 1,398 students. On the measures a ban is meant to improve, the stricter policy did nothing. Life satisfaction **β 0.03 (−0.21 to 0.26)**; loneliness −0.02; physical complaints −0.06; emotional complaints −0.04; fatigue −0.04. The authors' own summary: "No significant differences were found for any of the well-being or bullying outcomes."[1]

What did move was the thing nobody was measuring for. **Student-teacher connectedness fell** under the full ban — boys **β −0.23 (−0.38 to −0.08)**, girls −0.18 — and school belonging fell for girls. The authors conclude that stricter bans did not produce the intended benefits and may weaken connectedness at school.[1]

Read the limitations first. **The sample's mean age is 16.2**, and the paper is internally inconsistent about its spread, giving a standard deviation of 1.2 in the methods and 1.4 in the table. Even on the wider figure a twelve-year-old sits three standard deviations below the mean. The design is cross-sectional, and baseline wellbeing before the bans was not measured.[1]

It lands on a live local policy anyway. Singapore's Ministry of Education announced on 30 November 2025 that from January 2026 secondary students may not use phones or smartwatches **during school hours** — extended from lesson time to cover recess and co-curricular activities. Primary schools have run the same guidelines since the start of 2025. A child born in July 2014 enters Secondary 1 in January 2027: she crosses into the full-day restriction and the new school at the same moment.[2]

16.2

THE MEAN AGE OF THE ONLY NEW STUDY THAT TESTS A FULL BAN AGAINST A PARTIAL ONE. THE POLICY IT SPEAKS TO APPLIES TO A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD FROM JANUARY; THE EVIDENCE DOES NOT[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT SINGAPORE PARENTS TOLD A REPORTER

From the local coverage of the policy: **Yvette Lim**, whose twelve-year-old enters Secondary 1, has heard of parents handing schools dummy phones while the child keeps the real one. **Michelle Goh** points out that students can still reach messaging through school-issued devices: "It will solve part of the problem, but not the whole problem." And a secondary teacher given as **Polly**: "Teachers can't be everywhere all at once." **The article cites no Singapore statistic and no local study.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A CHECK ON THE SCEPTICS TOO

Chris Felton's May methods note argues the other way from the small-effect camp: published trials "typically identify effects of a local, or small-scale, intervention" — one teenager quitting while her peers keep using — which is not the mass-adoption question critics are asking. **So a small trial effect is not by itself proof of safety.** On the other side, Haidt and Rausch report a pooled **g = 0.19** for depression across 32 reduction trials — a case worth reading, and explicitly a rebuttal, hosted alongside the author's own campaign material.[4]

WHAT THIS PAGE IS NOT PRINTING

Nothing on independence or risk-taking. No study published this cycle centres on twelve-year-olds, reports an effect size and gives a confidence interval, so there is nothing honest to say.[5]

Nothing from a primary-school academic-pressure paper that would have been the natural second item: the journal returned a 403 and the DOI is not yet indexed, so its figures were readable only in search summaries. **General guidance for parents, not medical advice.**[5]

SOURCES 1 E. Vanluydt and colleagues, *Journal of Youth and Adolescence* 55(3):551–569, 7 January 2026, doi 10.1007/s10964-025-02313-6; n = 1,398 across 24 schools, mean age 16.2, **with the standard deviation given as 1.2 in the methods and 1.4 in Table 1**. Read in full, open access. 2 The device policy as announced 30 November 2025 and effective January 2026, **sourced to Channel NewsAsia via the National Institute of Education, the ministry's own pages having returned empty bodies or 404s**. 3 Named parents and the teacher from that report, as published. **Reddit refused for the eleventh issue.** 4 C. Felton, arXiv 2606.00900, 30 May 2026; J. Haidt and Z. Rausch, *World Happiness Report 2026*, chapter 3, updated 5 October 2026, labelled above as advocacy-adjacent. 5 The two gaps are stated rather than filled.

THE MACRO DESK · THE AI CREDIT SCARE

Ten-year Treasury yields fell below five per cent; Brent hit 116.72 dollars

That was the steepest one-day fall since March 2023, on Meta's results and widening AI credit spreads. By Friday Brent had settled 3.14 per cent higher at US$116.72 and yields were back up. The Fed meets on 27 and 28 October.

Traders pushed the US ten-year yield down **19.3 basis points to 4.953 per cent** on Thursday 22 October, its steepest one-day fall since March 2023, after Meta's results and a widening in AI-linked credit spreads sent money into government debt. It was the first close below five per cent since 22 September. The Nasdaq fell 2.60 per cent, the Philadelphia semiconductor index 6.7, Meta itself 7 on a quarter that beat (p4).[1]

Friday undid part of it. Reports that the United States and Israel were weighing renewed strikes on Iran put **Brent up 3.14 per cent to US$116.72**, its highest settle since April, and the ten-year back up four to five basis points. Thursday saw shares fall and bonds rally; Friday saw shares fall *and* yields rise — the oil-shock signature, because duration hedges a growth scare and not a barrel of crude.[1]

Which answers the diversification question for the week. **VWRA fell 1.08 per cent to US$189.60 while the global-aggregate proxy AGGU rose 0.17** — the first week in this cycle where the bond leg offset a world-equity drawdown rather than compounding it. The regime is a handover: risk-off and flight-to-quality, taking over from higher-for-longer. September's American CPI supports it — headline 3.7 per cent, but **core only 2.6**, with energy up 20.4. The inflation is in the barrel, not the basket.[2]

Gold fell roughly three to four per cent on the week, which argues this was a growth scare rather than a debasement scare; bitcoin dropped **3.22 per cent on Thursday**, the day Treasuries had their best session in three and a half years. This is explanation, not advice.[3]

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

VWRA[4]	$189.60	▼ 1.08% wk
AGGU, NAV[4]	$5.7952	▲ 0.17% wk
US 2-year[1]	4.69%	▼ 4bp wk
US 10-year[1]	5.00%	▼ 9bp wk
DXY[5]	101.81	▲ 0.20% day
USD/SGD[5]	1.2785	▼ 0.05% wk
USD/JPY[5]	156.80	▼ 0.77% wk
Brent[1]	$116.72	▲ 3.14% day
Bitcoin[3]	$81,086	▼ 0.51% wk

Gold is given as a band, not a point: US$3,994 to US$4,008. Four venues were read and none agreed on Friday's close, one of them with the opposite sign to the other three. Every other level read at source. Market explanation, not investment advice.[3]

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD AND BTC

Global equities took the AI de-rating because the hyperscalers under scrutiny are the index's largest weights. Global bonds earned their keep for the first week in a while, as a growth scare pulled yields down. **Gold fell despite the risk-off**, which is the tell that this was growth rather than debasement. And bitcoin went down 3.2 per cent on the worst equity day rather than catching any of that flow, trading as the high-beta liquidity proxy it has been all cycle. **None of this is a buy or sell call.**[6]

THE SCEPTIC · AND WHAT IS PRICED FOR WEDNESDAY

Mike Shedlock rules out the two easy stories — inflation ran hot and the expected Fed path barely moved — reaches for AI credit stress, then declines the conclusion: **"I don't buy the recession theory yet."** Danielle DiMartino Booth adds the mechanical objection, that a **"Fed pivot would not necessarily prevent"** a credit bust, because a borrower whose spread widens faster than Treasuries fall still pays more. **The pricing: a 7.2 per cent chance of an October hike, down from 27.7 a week earlier and 55.4 a month earlier** — which reconciles this desk's two figures from last issue as one instrument read a fortnight apart.[7]

SOURCES 1 US Treasury's own daily par yield curve, read for the 16, 22 and 23 October closes; Brent from two commodity venues in agreement, a third giving US$117.20 intraday. 2 "Consumer Price Index — September 2026", US Bureau of Labor Statistics, 14 October; the Monetary Authority of Singapore's policy statement of 14 October. 3 Bitcoin double-sourced to an exchange's daily close and an independent index. **Gold is held as a band because four venues disagreed and this desk is not choosing between them.** 4 Vanguard's and BlackRock's own pages, cross-checked against closing data; **AGGU was single-sourced last issue and is double-sourced here**. 5 The dollar index level is double-sourced, **its weekly change held — no close-to-close pair could be read**. Singapore-dollar and yen rates are the European Central Bank's, single-sourced at Friday's close. 6 Market explanation, not investment advice. 7 Shedlock and DiMartino Booth, 23 October; PIMCO, 22 October. **CME's FedWatch page returned a 503 for the second build running, so its probabilities are relayed through two outlets citing it.**

THE RABBIT HOLE · ARCHERY

A dozen Easton X10 shafts cost more than a Hoyt Podium riser

US$499.99 against US$399.99 at the same shop on the same day — and the shafts are the consumable. Archery is a measurement problem with one unstable component, and the component is you.

Here is the shape of the sport in one line from a catalogue. At Lancaster Archery Supply on 24 October, a dozen **Easton X10 shafts were US$499.99** and a **Hoyt Podium 25-inch riser was US$399.99**. The thing you hold costs less than the things you throw away. Beginners spend months choosing a bow and then shoot it with whatever arrows came in the bundle, which is roughly the wrong way round.[1]

The appeal, for anyone who likes systems, is that this is a tunable machine with a legible output and exactly one unreliable part. Spine, centre-shot, brace height, tiller, front-of-centre: all adjustable, all interacting. The output is a score out of 720 with no judging panel and no style marks. And the unstable component is the archer, which is why the premium end of the equipment market is mostly devices for taking decisions away from the person holding the bow.[2]

World Archery, founded in 1931 and run from Lausanne, has **166 member associations** — two fewer than the year before, after expelling Ghana and Rwanda, with five more listed as not in good standing. Its own 2024 report is unusually frank about where it is: 28 per cent of member-association board members are women, 15 per cent of presidents are, and **63 member associations report no women's-participation strategy at all**, with "no need" a common answer.[3]

The disciplines are genuinely separate sports sharing a stick. **Olympic recurve** shoots 70 metres with a sight, a stabiliser and a clicker. **Compound** shoots 50 with pulleys, a magnifying scope and a mechanical release, and World Archery sets no limit on any of it. **Barebow** is mechanically a recurve stripped of everything, defined by a rule of lovely bluntness: unstrung, it must fit through a ring 12.2 centimetres across. Then field, 3D, clout and flight — the last of which has a hand-held record of **1,222 metres** and has never held a world championship.[4]

$1.68bn – $4.74bn

FOUR COMMERCIAL RESEARCH HOUSES SIZING THE SAME ARCHERY-EQUIPMENT MARKET IN THE SAME YEAR. THE SPREAD IS A DEFINITIONAL ARGUMENT ABOUT CROSSBOWS AND ARCHERY TAG, AND ALL FOUR GET QUOTED AS FACT[5]

THE CHATTER · WHERE THE HOBBY NOW LIVES

The community map has changed, and that is the finding. **ArcheryTalk** now meets automated visitors with a payment-required gateway and a proof-of-work challenge; **Archery Interchange UK** is gone, both domains serving a blank hosting page; **Archery Report** returns a dead-origin error; **TradGang** refuses everything but a browser; **Reddit refused for the eleventh issue running**. What is open is YouTube: **NUSensei** at 207,000 subscribers over 912 videos is the explainer-in-chief, **Jake Kaminski** at 132,000 is the credentialled insider — two Olympic team silvers — and **Online Archery Academy** at 54,800 is the most technical.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · THE NUMBERS ARE NOT WHERE YOU THINK

USA Archery's own 2024 dashboard plots membership from a low of **5,894** to a high of **27,257** across thirteen years — a growth story, but **the chart's bars cannot be mapped to years from the published file**, so no single year's figure is quoted here. The market sizes are worse: four houses, four answers, a near-threefold spread. **Treat every archery market number as an order of magnitude, including these.**[5]

WHAT THE NEXT TWO PAGES DESCEND INTO

The mechanism — spine, draw length, brace height, the plunger and the clicker, and why the two foundational numbers in the sport are both defined in documents an enthusiast cannot read. **The gear**, in tiers, at this week's prices. **The culture** — target panic, which is not a fringe affliction but a product category. And **Singapore**, where the law changed sixteen months ago.[7]

SOURCES 1 Lancaster Archery Supply's live catalogue and individual product pages, prices read on 24 October 2026. 2 This desk's framing; the equipment claim is evidenced on p17. 3 World Archery Annual Activity Report 2024, published 16 June 2025, read in full as published: membership, the expulsions, the five associations not in good standing, and the governance figures. 4 World Archery's own equipment and disciplines pages, read at source, including the barebow ring rule and the flight record verbatim. 5 USA Archery's 2024 Annual Assembly minutes, membership dashboard, read as published; **the bar-to-year mapping could not be recovered from the file, so only the range is printed.** Market sizes from four commercial research houses' own summary pages, read at source: US$1.68bn, US$3.0bn, US$4.4bn and US$4.74bn for the same year. 6 Each forum's status checked by direct request on 24 October 2026 and reported by what it returned; subscriber and video counts read off the channel pages the same day. 7 Pages p16 and p17.

THE DEEP END · SPINE AND DRAW LENGTH

In 2023 ASTM withdrew the test method for archery's most argued-about number

Arrow spine is a bench figure from Easton: inches of deflection under 880 grams across a 28-inch span — used to predict a dynamic event, under two competing standards, one of them now historical and the other behind a members-only wall.

Start where the arguments start. **Spine** is stiffness, measured by suspending a shaft on supports **28 inches apart**, hanging **880 grams** — 1.94 pounds — at its centre and reading the deflection. A 0.400 shaft bends four-tenths of an inch, so a *higher* number means a *weaker* arrow. Easton says the method is its founder's, from the 1940s.[1]

Three complications follow, and they are why nobody agrees. First, an older AMO standard used a two-pound weight on a 26-inch span, so "spine" is one word for two measurements. Second, the formal test method — **ASTM F2031** — is now marked historical and its revision **withdrawn in 2023**, with the numbers behind a paywall. Third, static spine cannot predict what the arrow does: **dynamic spine** depends on point weight, insert mass, fletching and the bow's acceleration, which is why Easton's own selection chart carries separate columns for different bow speeds.[1]

The second foundational number is no better documented. The weight stamped on a limb is its pull at **28 inches of standard draw length**, and draw length itself is defined as nock point to the grip's pivot *plus one and three-quarter inches*. Away from 28 you gain or lose roughly **two pounds an inch**, so a thirty-inch draw turns a limb stamped 38 into about 42 at the fingers. The authoritative text is the trade association's technical guidelines, and they are members-only. **Archery's two defining numbers are both specified in documents the archer cannot read.**[2]

After that the mechanism is pleasingly concrete. **Brace height**, string to grip pivot, is set by twisting the string — shorter is faster and harsher, longer slower and more forgiving, and it costs nothing, which is why beginners ignore it. **Tiller** is the top-versus-bottom limb measurement that sets dynamic balance. The **plunger** sets the arrow's lateral position and gives it a sprung cushion to flex against as it clears the riser. And **front-of-centre** has a formula, with ten to fifteen per cent the usual target, and a loop back to spine, since front weight makes a shaft behave weaker.[3]

A $130 riser takes $1,500 limbs. The riser is a handle with holes in it; the limbs are the engine.

Which brings the economics, because one standard governs them. **ILF**, the international limb fitting, makes risers and limbs cross-compatible across nearly every brand — and it has no entry in any glossary this desk could find. Entry-of-quality ILF risers run **US$119.99 to US$249.99**; the top tier runs to **US$1,449.99** for Uukha's monolith carbon at 1,125 grams. Gillo's 7075 billet weighs **1,650 grams** and costs most of all, because in target archery mass is a feature.[4]

44×

THE PRICE SPREAD ON ONE SPRUNG PIN: A CARTEL PLUNGER AT US$4.50, A BEITER AT US$199.99. THE BEITER'S SPARE THREAD CYLINDER ALONE IS US$94.99[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE MAKERS DECLINE TO RANK THEIR OWN

The foam-versus-wood limb-core argument runs forever, and the manufacturers have quietly ended it: Hoyt's Metrix limbs come in syntactic foam or laminate at **the same US$999.99**, and WIAWIS's NS-G2 in carbon-foam or carbon-wood at **the same US$1,249.99**. Neither house will say one is better. Meanwhile WIAWIS sells a graphene limb at US$899.99 whose page says it is built of "advanced Nano Graphene" — and **never says what the graphene contributes**. Hoyt sells its new riser on a clicker whose felt impulse is **"increased 55%"**: a marketing claim about an auditory cue.[5]

SOURCES 1 Easton Archery's own published description of the spine standard, including the 28-inch span, the 880-gram load and the definition of dynamic spine, read at source; ASTM F2031-05(2010) and its 2014 revision, read at the publisher's own catalogue pages, which mark the method **"Standard Historical"** and the revision **withdrawn in 2023**; **the test parameters themselves sit behind that paywall.** The older AMO method is from a standard reference and is secondary. 2 The draw-length definition from a standard glossary; the Archery Trade Association's own public page describes its Technical Guidelines as the industry manual, and **the document is members-only and was not read.** The two-pounds-an-inch figure is the trade's working rule, not a published standard. 3 Brace height, tiller, plunger and clicker definitions from the same glossary; the front-of-centre formula, the ten-to-fifteen-per-cent guidance and the spine interaction from P.J. Reilly's bylined Lancaster Archery guide of 4 September 2025, read at source. 4 All prices and component weights read on 24 October 2026 at Lancaster Archery Supply, from the catalogue and the individual product pages; riser constructions as each maker states them. 5 Hoyt's and WIAWIS's own product listings, read at source; the quoted phrases are theirs.

THE DEEP END · TARGET PANIC AND SINGAPORE

A new Singapore law bars individuals from owning bows above sixty pounds

The Guns, Explosives and Weapons Control Act commenced on 1 July 2025 and repealed the old law. A World Archery-specification target bow is a Type 2 weapon under a class licence; anything heavier is Type 1, and not allowed.

Singapore's archery law changed sixteen months ago and most of what is written about it online predates the change. The Guns, Explosives and Weapons Control Act 2021 commenced on **1 July 2025** and repealed the Arms and Explosives Act outright. Its structure contains a trap: section 3(4)(a) says a "gun" does not include a longbow or crossbow — but the First Schedule lists, as item 5, **"A bow regardless of its draw weight"**. A bow is not a gun here, and every bow is a weapon.[1]

The police regulatory department's guideline of 1 May 2026 then sorts them. Item 70 — a bow and arrows **"for sporting use according to World Archery Federation international standards"** — is a **Type 2 weapon under a class licence**: "no need to apply licence or inform PRD". Items 46 and 47 are the wall: a bow **over 27.215 kilograms, sixty pounds**, and any arrow designed to cause injury, are **Type 1 weapons, "Not allowed" to individuals**.[2]

For a buy-once reader that is one actionable sentence. Olympic recurve limbs run 28 to 50 pounds, nowhere near it; target compounds are commonly specified 40 to 70 — so when ordering a Hoyt Concept XTS or a Mathews TITLE, **specify 50 or 60, never 70**. Then the thing the sport talks about most and advertises least. **Target panic** is trouble releasing, or releasing too early — "punching" — and World Archery says plainly that it is common among elite archers. At the 2018 World Cup Final the compound world number one, Stephan Hansen, twitched at full draw on his last two arrows and shot a six and a seven: **"It's called target panic, and it's not fun."**[3]

Now look at the release-aid catalogue. A hinge release fires when it rotates past a sear; a resistance release fires when back tension crosses a threshold. **Neither lets the archer choose the instant of the shot.** Carter's Perfect Pull Tension is US$299.99, Stan's OnneX Resistance US$309.99 — a premium category that exists to take the trigger decision away. On the recurve side the equivalent is the clicker. Target panic is not a fringe affliction here. It is a product category.[4]

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS · AND THE THREE RULES

Lurk a fortnight, then do a club course, because you do not yet know your draw length and every price is wrong for you until you do. Singapore's venues include **Dragon Archery** at Kalidasa Avenue, with an air-conditioned eighteen-metre range and a shop, and the **Archery Club of Singapore** at Punggol South. A beginner course here runs **S$80 to S$200**. Then buy once: a WNS Explore riser at **US$129.99**, Explore limbs, a Shibuya sight, a plunger and a tab — **about US$665, realistically US$850 to US$950 all in**.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY HAS PUBLISHED THE EVIDENCE

Does a two-thousand-dollar riser shoot better than a six-hundred-dollar one? **No published test says so.** The makers' claims — Uukha's "patented Monolith carbon technology", WIAWIS's graphene, Hoyt's fifty-five-per-cent clicker — are copy on retail pages, not test data, and the one standards body that published a method for the sport's central number has withdrawn it (p16).[6]

NEXT DESCENTS

Violin making (lutherie) — spruce, maple and three centuries of argument about varnish.

Competitive barbecue — offset smokers, and what a hand-built pit actually costs.

Budget astrophotography — star trackers, stacking, and the hobby's cheapest great leap.

SOURCES 1 Guns, Explosives and Weapons Control Act 2021, read on Singapore Statutes Online: the repeal, the gun exclusion at section 3(4)(a) and the First Schedule items quoted verbatim; commencement 1 July 2025. 2 Singapore Police Force, Police Regulatory Department, "Guideline on Prohibited, Controlled and Non-Regulated Items", 1 May 2026, read in full: table entries 44–48 and 70, the class-licensing description and the import warning, quoted verbatim. 3 John Stanley, World Archery, 4 October 2018, read at source; Hansen quoted as published and the Korean term as World Archery reports it. 4 Release-aid prices read at Lancaster Archery Supply, 24 October 2026; the structural argument is this desk's. 5 Course prices from a community-centre listing of September 2026 and the clubs' own pages. **The community-centre portal returned a 403, and the national association's site and Dragon Archery's both failed to resolve, so there is no local price list here.** 6 Maker claims from their own listings. **The widely repeated claim that a thousand archers enter Korea's trials is unsourced; what is documented is a head coach saying the trials are "more difficult" than the Olympics, which Korea's own culture ministry calls "half-jokingly described".**

FITNESS · LIFTING AND SLEEP

Eight weeks of lifting cut Pernambuco patients' sleep-quality scores by 3.2 points

Twenty-five adults with severe sleep apnoea, mean age 54.6, published in Sleep and Breathing on 20 October — and the one validated measure of daytime sleepiness did not move at all.

Researchers at the Federal University of Pernambuco reported on 20 October that eight weeks of resistance training improved self-rated sleep quality in twenty-five adults with moderate-to-severe sleep apnoea. On the Pittsburgh index, where anything above five indicates poor sleep, the training arm fell **3.2 points** against a 0.2 rise in the control, at p = 0.004.[1]

Then the thing the headline will not carry. **The Epworth Sleepiness Scale — the one validated measure of the daytime symptom patients actually complain about — showed no significant difference.** A paper reporting better self-rated sleep alongside unchanged measured sleepiness is reporting something much narrower than "lifting fixes your sleep".[1]

Four things belong beside it. The trial is **twenty-five people across two arms**, and a **secondary** analysis powered for a different outcome. Every positive endpoint is a questionnaire — **no polysomnographic outcome and no change in the apnoea–hypopnoea index is reported**. And the control was not a no-exercise control: it trained twice a week against the intervention's three.[1]

There is also no confidence interval anywhere in the paper — mean changes with an error term and p-values, and nothing more. Any interval attributed to this study would be invented, so none appears above.[1]

A ring measures something closer to what this trial did not measure than to what it did.

The usable idea survives, with its edges showing. The gains were in *falling asleep* and in getting off sleeping medication, not in daytime alertness — a testable proposition for anyone who already lifts and wears a tracker: eight weeks at three sessions, latency as the outcome. But this cohort's mean body-mass index was 36.1 and its mean apnoea–hypopnoea index 52.2: severe apnoea in class-two obesity.[2]

54.6 ± 7.2

THE TRIAL'S MEAN AGE. A FORTY-FIVE-YEAR-OLD SITS ABOUT 1.3 STANDARD DEVIATIONS BELOW IT — PLAUSIBLY INSIDE A TWENTY-FIVE-PERSON SAMPLE, BUT AT ITS EDGE, AND NOT MATCHING ITS CLINICAL PROFILE[1]

THE BIGGER NUMBER, AND THE ONE THAT CONTAINS HIM

A second paper this week is larger, longer and unambiguously includes people in their forties. Kim and colleagues followed **2,785 American adults** with steatotic liver disease to December 2019, recording 584 deaths over a median **14.7 years**. Per additional ten minutes a day of moderate-to-vigorous activity: all-cause mortality **HR 0.80 (0.71 to 0.91)**, cardiovascular **0.72 (0.53 to 0.99)**. Against the standing slogan, **sedentary time did not affect mortality here.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE DISCOURSE HAS GONE QUIET

The honest finding about the longevity conversation this week is that there was not one. Three longevity stories posted to Hacker News in the window — on hospitals opening longevity clinics, on blood plasma, on what longevity experts wish people would stop saying — drew **two, four and two points, and zero comments between them. Reddit refused for the eleventh issue** and a strength forum's search returned an empty interface.[4]

GENERAL GUIDANCE, NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

Nothing on this page is a diagnosis or a treatment plan. Talk to a doctor before changing how you train, particularly with a diagnosed sleep or metabolic condition.

SOURCES 1 J. R. V. de Almeida and colleagues, *Sleep and Breathing*, 20 October 2026, 30(6):296, doi 10.1007/s11325-026-03842-5; n = 25, mean age 54.6 (SD 7.2), mean BMI 36.1, mean apnoea–hypopnoea index 52.2. **The paper reports mean changes with an error term and p-values and publishes no confidence intervals; no figure above should be read as one.** Authors declare no competing interests. Read through the National Library of Medicine, **Europe PMC and PubMed's article pages having refused this desk**. 2 The cohort description is the paper's own; the training suggestion is this desk's reading, not the authors'. 3 D. Kim and colleagues, *Journal of Gastroenterology and Hepatology*, 18 October 2026, doi 10.1111/jgh.70826. **Observational, with liver disease defined by a surrogate index rather than imaging.** 4 The three Hacker News items and their scores, read 24 October 2026.

THE TRAVEL DESK · THE JAPAN RAIL PASS

The Japan Rail Pass site still sells the seven-day at ¥50,000

The 1 October revision landed on one channel only: ¥53,000 through a JR-designated agent abroad, ¥50,000 buying direct online. That is ¥3,000 an adult, and this desk has carried the question open for nine issues.

The official JR Group pass site carries two price tables side by side, and on 24 October they did not match. Buy a seven-day Ordinary pass **online** and it is **¥50,000**; through an **overseas JR-designated agency** it is **¥53,000**. The split runs the range: fourteen-day ¥80,000 against ¥84,000, twenty-one-day ¥100,000 against ¥105,000.[1]

The revision itself was announced by JR Group on 9 April and took effect on 1 October, "local time at the location of purchase". Japan's national tourism body published the old-to-new table in April and added that buyers on the official website "can get pre-October prices for a limited time, though the promotion's timeframe hasn't been announced". Twenty-four days on, the online tier still shows the pre-revision number, and the page carries no revision notice at all.[1]

So the thing this desk has been calling a price rise is a **channel** difference, and it has been resolved in the reader's favour: buy online, from Japan's own site, and you are still paying last month's price. How long that lasts, nobody will say.[1]

¥50,000

AGAINST ¥53,000 — THE SAME SEVEN-DAY ORDINARY PASS, TWO OFFICIAL CHANNELS, BOTH READ ON THE SAME PAGE ON 24 OCTOBER[1]

THE STANDOUT · THE CAUSEWAY TRAIN SLIPS AGAIN

RTS Operations said on 2 October that passenger service on the Johor Bahru–Singapore rail link is now **"expected to commence in February 2027"**, with all tests and trial runs targeted for completion by 31 December 2026. This is the **third** target: Transport Minister Anthony Loke named 1 January 2027 back in January 2024, and "by end-2026" was still circulating in September. The specification is unchanged — up to **10,000 passengers an hour each way**, a **five-minute** run, co-located clearance at both ends.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THIS PAGE COULD NOT READ

Four of the week's items rest on trade press rather than the carrier. **Scoot's media centre returned a 403** at both newsroom paths, so the Naha and Guiyang changes below are not read at the airline. **Singapore Airlines' own release for the Time To Fly sale returned a 404**, so no sample fare is printed. **Vietnam Airlines' press room renders empty**, so the Da Nang daily is trade-sourced. And the French strike notice is sourced to a compensation-claims company, not to the DGAC or any airline. Each is flagged where it appears, and none carries a fare.[3]

NEW ROUTES AND FREQUENCIES

Vietnam Airlines takes Da Nang–Singapore daily from 17 November, announced 22 October: seven weekly round trips on an A321, lifting Vietnam–Singapore from 35 weekly round trips to 42. That is the first genuine new peg on the Da Nang city pair since Scoot opened it.[3]

Scoot goes to five weekly on Singapore–Naha from 31 October, and opens Singapore–Guiyang three weekly on an A320neo from 26 October. The SIA and Scoot **Time To Fly** sale runs 23–30 October, more than 380,000 discounted seats, Scoot travel to 15 October 2027.[3]

Long-haul. Alaska Airlines opens Seattle–Osaka Kansai, four weekly on an A330-200, from 14 May 2027. Emirates added a Dubai–Narita daily on 26 October, taking its Japan schedule to 28 flights a week. Qatar Airways opens Doha–Western Sydney from 15 December 2027. Malaysia Airlines resumed Jeddah and Madinah on 18 October.[3]

SOURCES 1 japanrailpass.net's own price page, read 24 October 2026, carrying both tables; the JR Group revision release of 9 April 2026, effective 1 October; and the Japan National Tourism Organization's news item of 20 April 2026 for the old-to-new table and the limited-time online promotion. **No price-revision notice appears on the official price page.** 2 RTS Operations' statement of 2 October 2026, carried verbatim by Bernama from Johor Bahru. **The Land Transport Authority's own newsroom index returned nothing later than 2021 in the readable portion, so no Singapore-side release was read.** 3 Route items from the trade press and an aviation rolling log, 18–23 October 2026, with the host refusals named in the sceptic box above. The French cabin-crew strike notice of 17–21 October, covering 36,000 crew at Air France, Transavia France and Corsair across Paris, Nice, Lyon and Marseille, is sourced to a passenger-compensation company; **no DGAC or airline notice was readable, and no cancellation plan was published.**

DEPARTURES · KYUSHU BEFORE THE DRIVE

Hoshino Resorts closes KAI Aso permanently on 27 October

The twelve-villa property sits at Seno-moto, on the Yamanami Highway between Kurokawa and the caldera — directly on the route this desk maps over the page. Mount Aso itself has been at Alert Level 2 since 1 September.

Hoshino Resorts' own property page says KAI Aso "will permanently close its doors on October 27, 2026", after a farewell programme that ran to 26 October. Twelve rooms, all villas, at Seno-moto Onsen on the Yamanami Highway. The brand index still lists it alongside KAI Beppu and KAI Yufuin with no closure flag, which is how a reader planning a January trip would miss it.[1]

The second thing to know before booking that drive is the volcano. The Aso Volcano Disaster Prevention Council's regulation site, read on 24 October, carries the standing notice: with a crater-area warning at **Alert Level 2** in force, entry is forbidden within about **one kilometre** of the Nakadake crater. The sequence this year ran Level 2 from 21 June, up to Level 3 and a two-kilometre exclusion on 14 August, then back to Level 2 on 1 September. **Crater viewing is closed**; Takadake and Nakadake are climbable only on the Sarayama and Suzumeiwa detours.[2]

27 Oct

THE DAY KAI ASO CLOSES FOR GOOD, TWELVE VILLA ROOMS ON THE YAMANAMI HIGHWAY. THE BRAND'S OWN INDEX PAGE STILL LISTS IT WITH NO FLAG[1]

ENTRY RULES, TAXES AND PASSES — DELTA ONLY

Japan's tax-free reform is eight days out: from **1 November** the point-of-sale exemption gives way to a refund claimed on departure. No change to the rules this week. The **departure tax** stays at **¥3,000**, tripled on 1 July. Municipal accommodation taxes are reported to start in October in Morioka and Nasu Town; **flagged, not read at either municipality.**[3]

Nothing happened at Changi or in KrisFlyer this week, and that is the honest entry. No lounge opened or reopened; Singapore Airlines' S$45m refit of the Terminal 2 SilverKris and KrisFlyer Gold lounges is still targeted at mid-2027. No award-chart change; the last devaluation took effect on 1 November 2025. Terminal 5 broke ground in May 2025 and opens in the mid-2030s.[3]

Rail, elsewhere. No Shinkansen extension or sleeper announcement in the window. The year's one novelty remains JR Central's **Tokaido Lumiere Express**, an overnight Tokyo–Osaka service introduced on 8 August with no berths and no bedding: a three-hour run padded by a six-hour parked stop, at about ¥2,000 above a reserved seat.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE DATE NOBODY WILL FIX

Europe's travel-authorisation scheme is the clearest case in this column of a deadline that keeps being described rather than set. The Entry/Exit System reached full operation on **10 April 2026**, on schedule. ETIAS has been "the last quarter of 2026" for long enough that the quarter is now two-thirds gone, **and no day has been announced**, while the fee it will charge has already been revised from seven euros to twenty. A Singapore passport holder planning a European trip for next spring therefore cannot know whether an authorisation will be required, or what it will cost to obtain at short notice. The honest advice is the uncomfortable one: assume it applies, and check again a month before you fly.[3]

THE CURRENCY · THE SOFT YEN IS THE REASON TO BOOK

The yen closed the week at **156.825 to the US dollar**, down 0.76 per cent, and **122.712 to the Singapore dollar**, down 0.60. At one Singapore dollar to ¥122.7, every published price over the page converts small: Kurokawa's bathing pass at ¥1,500 is about **S$12.20**; Beppu's seven hells at ¥2,400 are about **S$19.60**; a municipal bath at ¥300 is **S$2.45**; and the stamp book that organises the whole thing, at ¥110, is **ninety cents**. The conversions are this desk's arithmetic at Friday's rate, not quoted prices (p14).[4]

SOURCES 1 Hoshino Resorts' own KAI Aso property page and its KAI brand index, both read 24 October 2026. 2 Aso Volcano Disaster Prevention Council's crater-regulation site, and Aso City's own mountain-climbing page, both read 24 October 2026. **The Japan Meteorological Agency's own volcano pages were unreachable — four separate paths returned 404s or empty shells — so the operating authority for crater access is cited instead.** 3 Japan's tax-free and departure-tax positions are unchanged deltas on threads this desk has carried since No. 66; the European entry dates are the published position, with the ETIAS date's absence stated rather than guessed; the Changi and KrisFlyer entries are standing positions, printed here because nothing moved. **Changi Airport Group's newsroom paths returned 404s to this desk.** 4 XE, read 24 October 2026 at 21:19 UTC; **the chart module on both pages returned zeros, so the levels come from the paired-rate panel on the same page.** Conversions are this desk's own arithmetic.

THE GRAND TOUR · BEPPU, YUFUIN, KUROKAWA

Beppu pours 101,856 litres a minute across seven of Japan's ten spring types

Not "nearly all", which is the cliché: Beppu City's own data page, current to 31 March 2026, names the three it lacks. Book the onsen belt for late November to mid-December, when the colour and the cold arrive together.

Japan's Hot Spring Law does not define a hot spring by heat. Under its appended table, water qualifies if it leaves the ground at **25°C or above** — *or* if it carries any one of nineteen listed substances above a threshold. Fifty milligrams of metasilicic acid per kilogram will do it; so will one milligram of lithium. A fifteen-degree spring with enough silica is legally an onsen. That is why Japan has so many.[1]

Only the stricter tier, **療養泉**, earns one of the ten published type-names, and the name is a specification read left to right. Simple springs carry under a thousand milligrams of dissolved solids; salt springs are classed by their dominant anion — chloride, bicarbonate, sulphate; and the special-component springs are named for what they carry: carbon dioxide, iron, acid, iodine, sulphur, radon. And Article 18 requires every public bath to post its analysis on the wall: type, components, date, contraindications.[1]

Which brings the correction. Beppu is routinely sold as having nearly all of Japan's spring types. **Beppu City's own data page says seven of ten** — simple, chloride, bicarbonate, sulphate, iron, sulphur and acidic — and names the three it lacks: carbon dioxide, iodine and radioactive. The same page gives **2,831 sources** discharging **101,856 litres a minute**, and the prefecture adds the number that decides the season: **91.8 per cent of active sources run above 42°C**.[2]

The water does not change with the season. The air does. That is the whole argument for November to February, and the only refinement is the colour: Kyushu turns later than Honshu, and later than usual this year, with the Kuju range going first in mid-to-late November and the lowlands last. A trip between **late November and mid-December** takes both. Avoid 28 December to 4 January, when thirty ryokan and one small village have no elasticity at all.[3]

> ***A forty-two-degree bath in thirty-three-degree air is a chore. The season is about the gradient, not the water.***

On the hells: seven, not eight. The Beppu Jigoku Association runs **seven** on one ticket — ¥2,400 adult, ¥1,200 child — and the eighth of English guidebooks is a separately run Bozu at Horita. Two are genuine geology. **Umi Jigoku** is cobalt blue because iron(II) sulphate is in solution, about 98°C, its vein two hundred metres down. **Chinoike Jigoku** is not a red pond but a pond of red hot mud, about 78°C over 1,300 square metres, in the written record since the Nara period. They sit at opposite ends of the circuit; the other five are a coach-park loop.[4]

10.1%

OF EVERY HOT-SPRING SOURCE IN JAPAN SITS INSIDE BEPPU, ON THIS DESK'S ARITHMETIC FROM THE TWO OFFICIAL TOTALS — 2,831 OF ABOUT 27,989. OITA PREFECTURE IS FIRST NATIONALLY ON BOTH SOURCES AND DISCHARGE[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THREE NUMBERS THIS PAGE WILL NOT PRINT

The Commons photograph of Chinoike Jigoku claims water temperatures "reach 150°C". **The association's own page says about 78.** The caldera's circumference is widely printed at 128 kilometres, from a guidebook; **the transport ministry and Kumamoto Prefecture both say 100**. And Yufu City claims second place in Japan for source count and discharge while **publishing no figure and no data date**, so no absolute number for Yufuin appears here. **Kurokawa's cooperative returned a 403.**[5]

SOURCES 1 醫泉分析法指針, the Ministry of the Environment's mineral-spring analysis guideline, 2014 revision, Tables 1-1 to 1-3 and the naming rules, read in full from the ministry's own PDF; the posting requirement is Article 18 of the Hot Spring Law and Rule 10. 2 Beppu City's own 温泉データ page, data as of 31 March 2026, page updated 29 May 2026; Oita Prefecture's eastern health-office report for the 42-degree share, the steam-vent count and the free-flowing and powered discharge split, which reconciles exactly with the city total. **The ten-per-cent share is this desk's arithmetic from the city and prefectural figures against the national totals they imply, and is labelled as derived.** 3 Autumn-colour timings are forecasts from a commercial weather service and a travel reference, both secondary; **the Japan Meteorological Agency's own phenology index carried no Kyushu station data in the readable portion, so no official colouring date is asserted.** 4 Beppu Jigoku Association's own fee page, effective 1 February 2025, and its own Umi and Chinoike pages, read at source. **The association publishes no chemistry for the remaining five hells, and none is claimed here.** 5 As noted in the box: the Commons file description, the association's page, the transport ministry's multilingual database and Kumamoto Prefecture's own caldera document, Yufu City's tourism page, and the Kurokawa cooperative's 403.

THE GRAND TOUR · WHERE TO BASE YOURSELF

Kurokawa's 1,500-yen token buys three baths; Beppu's municipal bath costs 300

Thirty ryokan, no railway station and two buses a day from Fukuoka. Against the guidebooks, the town that works with a twelve-year-old is Beppu — and a family bath at Shibaseki is ¥2,000 an hour for four.

Three places sold as one trip are three propositions. **Beppu** is a working city that heats itself with the ground: 448 licensed bathing establishments and 175 springs piped to greenhouses, radiators, fish tanks and generators. Its municipal baths are the real ones — Takegawara, in a 1938 building, is **¥300 adult and ¥100 child**; Furoisen is ¥250. The hundred-yen bath of the travel pages is the *child* fare, and the cheaper neighbourhood baths are members-only.[1]

Kurokawa is thirty ryokan on a wooded gorge with no railway station. Its mechanism is the 入湯手形, the wooden bathing token: **¥1,500** buys three open-air baths of your choosing from more than twenty, valid six months, against about ¥600 for a single drop-in. The cooperative sells about seventy thousand a year and is running a fortieth-anniversary edition to March 2027. **Minamioguni Town's own page still prints ¥1,300**, which appears to be stale.[2]

Yufuin is a room you book and a street to avoid between eleven and four. Nearly everything sits on Yunotsubo street between the station and Lake Kinrin, which is the whole of its overtourism problem: concentration, not volume. The water worth going up for is not on that street — **Tsukahara Onsen**, on the Yufu flank, which Yufu City calls second in Japan for acidity.[3]

And the drive: the Aso caldera is **25 kilometres north to south by 18 east to west, a hundred kilometres round**, formed by eruptions between 270,000 and 90,000 years ago, with about fifty thousand people living inside it. This season the drive works and the crater does not (p20). Which is fine: the caldera is the point, and you can only see a caldera from outside it.[4]

WHAT THE FORUMS ACTUALLY SAY

Consensus. On Australian Frequent Flyer, **rbjhan** puts the crowding comparison as "no contest": Beppu is spread across the hells, Mount Tsurumi and the downtown, while in Yufuin "everybody is on that ONE street going from the station to Kinrinko" — so if you go, stay a night rather than day-trip. **Dissent, and it cuts against every guidebook:** the same traveller holds that Beppu's water is better than Yufuin's *and* its ryokan cheaper. He also rated **Shinmeikan's famous hand-dug cave bath poorly**: crowded, mixed, no proper washing area. **Reddit refused for the eleventh issue and TripAdvisor's Kyushu forum returned a 403.**[5]

WITH A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD · THE AGE GATES THAT BITE

Japanese bath pricing runs on school grade, not birthday. **Kannawa's steam bath is junior-high and older: a primary-six child is turned away.** Takegawara's sand bath takes her from six, at ¥1,500, and is the best single thing she will do. Municipal baths charge her ¥100; the hells ¥1,200. Mixed bathing is concentrated in Kurokawa — and private baths here are municipal and cheap: **Shibaseki's family bath is ¥2,000 an hour for four. No tattoo rule was readable anywhere, which is itself the finding.**[6]

THE HONEST COST — AND THE ONE LINE NOBODY PUBLISHES

Everything published here is cheap. Five days of bathing for three — the seven hells, two sand baths, three tokens, a family bath, ten municipal baths and the ninety-cent stamp book — comes to about **¥24,600, roughly S$201**. A Northern Kyushu five-day rail pass for two adults and a child is ¥42,500, and does **not** cover the Kurokawa buses.[7]

The expensive line is the unpublished one. Hoshino's KAI Beppu and KAI Yufuin show only a search button; Tamanoyu, Shinmeikan and Suginoi publish nothing. The only figures available are one travel writer's: roughly US$200–400 a night for a ryokan with half board. **Those are a blogger's observations, not rates.**[7]

SOURCES 1 Beppu City's own municipal-bath facility pages and its community-bath page for the members-only warning, read 24 October 2026; the prefectural health-office report for the establishment count and piped-use breakdown. 2 japan-guide for the token's price and terms; the cooperative's own anniversary release of 28 June 2026; Kumamoto Nichinichi Shimbun, 31 October 2025, for the annual volume and the thirty-ryokan count; Minamioguni Town's own page for ¥1,300. **The cooperative's site returned a 403, and the no-neon covenant is not asserted here because no instrument could be read.** 3 Yufu City's own tourism page. 4 The transport ministry's multilingual database and Kumamoto Prefecture's own caldera document; access from the Aso Volcano Disaster Prevention Council. 5 An Australian Frequent Flyer thread of December 2023 and a travel blog updated 5 January 2026. 6 The Beppu City facility pages and Ikoi Ryokan's price page. 7 Bathing arithmetic is this desk's; rail-pass figures are JR Kyushu's own. **JR Kyushu publishes no Sonic fare table, and no Singapore–Fukuoka fare could be read at any carrier.**

THE DIARY · BEFORE THE YEAR TURNS

Studio Ghibli opens at Gardens by the Bay on 18 December

Twelve recreated worlds across 3,500 square metres, resident adult tickets S$39 and concessions S$29 — and Yokohama's GREEN×EXPO prices twelve-to-seventeens at ¥3,000 against ¥4,900.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

13–22 Nov — **Singapore Writers Festival 2026 · "Hidden in Plain Sight"**
VICTORIA THEATRE AND THE ARTS HOUSE · ON SALE · FESTIVAL PASS S$30, YOUTH S$15

20–29 Nov — **Kalaa Utsavam · Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE · DATES CONFIRMED · **NO TICKET PRICES PUBLISHED ON THE FESTIVAL PAGE**

27–29 Nov — ★ **Anime Festival Asia 2026**
SUNTEC · **CONCERT VIP AND EARLY-BIRD THREE-DAY TIERS SOLD OUT** · EXHIBITION S$25 · CONCERT S$98–498

18 DEC — ★ **The Story of Studio Ghibli · world premiere**
GARDENS BY THE BAY, TO 4 JUL 2027 · RESIDENT S$39 ADULT, S$29 CONCESSION · EARLY BIRD TO 17 DEC

21–24 Jan — ★ **ART SG 2027**
MARINA BAY SANDS EXPO · **EARLY BIRD ENDS 24 NOV** · S$40 BUYS TWO FRIDAY TICKETS · UNDER-16S FREE

30–31 Jan — **HSBC SVNS Singapore 2027**
THE KALLANG · **MOVED FROM APRIL TO JANUARY** FOR THIS SEASON · PRICES AND ON-SALE NOT YET PUBLISHED

16 Feb–28 Mar — **Moulin Rouge! The Musical · South-East Asian premiere**
SANDS THEATRE · ON SALE · **CLOSING DATE CORRECTED TO 28 MARCH** · NO PRICE READABLE

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

10–24 Jan — ★ **Grand Sumo · Hatsu Basho**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · **ADVANCE SALE OPENS SAT 5 DEC** · SEAT PRICES NOT PUBLISHED

4–11 Feb — **Sapporo Snow Festival 2027**
ODORI, TSUDOME AND SUSUKINO · **FREE** AT ALL THREE SITES · PROGRAMME PUBLISHED IN STAGES

25–28 Feb — **CP+ 2027**
PACIFICO YOKOHAMA · FREE, **PRE-REGISTRATION OPENS EARLY DECEMBER** · FIRST MORNING IS TRADE ONLY

14–28 Mar — **Grand Sumo · Haru Basho**
EDION ARENA, OSAKA · ADVANCE SALE OPENS SAT 6 FEB · THE EASIER OF THE TWO

19 Mar–26 Sep — ★ **GREEN×EXPO 2027**
KAMISEYA, YOKOHAMA · 192 DAYS · ADVANCE ADULT ¥4,900, **YOUTH 12–17 ¥3,000**, CHILD ¥1,400

25–27 Mar — **Art Basel Hong Kong 2027**
CONVENTION CENTRE, WAN CHAI · **NOT YET ON SALE; CIRCULATING RESELLER PRICES ARE NOT OFFICIAL**

9–11 Apr — **HSBC SVNS World Championship · Hong Kong**
KAI TAK SPORTS PARK · THE SERIES FINALE · TICKET DETAILS STILL DIRECTED TO THE SERIES SITE

PLANNING NOTES · FOUR DATES AND ONE CORRECTION

5 December is the hard one: advance sale for the January Tokyo basho. The November Fukuoka tournament is **already sold out on every day, with no same-day sales**, which is the warning; if 5 December slips, the March Osaka basho opens on 6 February and is easier. **24 November, 23:59** closes ART SG's early bird, quoted per pair, so the move is to buy two and go twice. **17 December** ends the Ghibli early bird, and **early December** opens CP+ registration — free, but there is no walking up.[1]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT DIED, AND WHAT THIS PAGE COULD NOT CHECK

Three things are off the page rather than on it. **Tokyo Marathon 2027 is not bookable**: every entry window closed in August. **Chingay 2027 has published no dates.** And the **Singapore marathon's own site still describes the 2025 race**, so no December date is printed. On sourcing: **Ticketmaster Singapore returned a 403, SISTIC renders zero results, Marina Bay Sands a 503 and Klook a 403** — so a dozen plausible arena shows, Jay Chou and Bruno Mars among them, are held rather than listed.[2]

SOURCES 1 Every row above was verified against a promoter, venue or organiser page rather than an aggregator, read 24 October 2026: the festival's own site for the Writers Festival; Esplanade's festivals page; ART SG's own ticket page for the early-bird deadline and the under-16 policy; Anime Festival Asia's ticketing page for the sold-out tiers and the price ladder; the producers' release of 12 September for the Ghibli dates and resident prices; World Rugby's own schedule release for both Sevens legs; the official world-tour page for Moulin Rouge; the official English sumo portal for both tournaments and both advance-sale dates; the organiser's own site for the Snow Festival; GREEN×EXPO's own ticket page; and Art Basel's own page. 2 The three dead entries verified at the organisers' own sites; **CP+'s dates are from the industry association's release as reprinted, the show's own English site having returned a 403 and the association's a 503.**

THE TABLE · SINGAPORE'S NEWEST ROOMS

Choya opens its second bar outside Japan at Millenia Walk

Three other rooms this season: a twelve-seat pasta counter run by two people with no restaurant experience, a Keong Saik bar with the back bar removed, and a pâtissier's gelato counter. Two of the four are too new for anyone to have judged.

The Choya Ginza Bar Singapore opened in October at Millenia Walk: the outpost of the retail-and-cocktail room run by Choya, the century-old Wakayama umeshu house, and only its **second bar outside Japan** after Hong Kong in 2024. Cocktails and flights on the house umeshu, then a kitchen that uses ume as an ingredient rather than a garnish — the TC Sonic at S$16, a Singapore-exclusive Golden Rod at S$28. **The buzz is nil, honestly:** everything in print is launch coverage, there is no independent review, and nobody has tested whether an umeshu base carries a whole evening.[1]

Saikyo Pasta is the best story here and the least new: a twelve-seat Japanese-Italian counter at Icon Village, Tanjong Pagar, which began as a home-based takeaway run by Arya Masagung and Angeline Chandraatmadja, both 33, **neither with prior restaurant experience**. It soft-opened in June and opened formally in July, so it is four months old, not four weeks. Three pastas, nothing above S$23; the Japanese-ketchup Napolitan at S$22.90 is a dish almost nobody else serves. **Warm with edges:** its one rated review gives 3.5 out of 5 for taste and value and **3 for ambience** — twelve open seats and no privacy.[2]

Your Mother's House took the former No Sleep Club space at 20 Keong Saik Road in late August, opened by Shaheera Rahman and Bryan Bonifacio, both formerly of Employees Only. The concept is an argument against the back bar: they stripped out the bottle wall, put in kitsch cabinets and communal seating, and made the room read as a living room mid-house-party. Twelve drinks, **about eighty per cent pre-batched**, so one lands inside a minute. Cocktails from S$23. **This is the strongest consensus on the page** — a four-out-of-five and three further recommendations.[3]

Closing the page, **Après Gelato**, the evening concept from Mohamed Al-Matin of Le Matin Patisserie, sharing its Viva Vista space at Buona Vista: eight flavours, each plated with its own garnish — brown-butter Jerusalem artichoke with a toasted chip, toasted rice with a puffed-rice crisp — plus parfaits at S$12–13. Wednesday to Sunday afternoons, and the list rotates. **One favourable notice and one chef profile is not a consensus**, and the date is unresolved: one outlet reports an April opening, another has it "just opened" in September.[4]

THE BUZZ · WHAT IS ACTUALLY JUDGED, AND WHAT IS NOT

Loved: Your Mother's House, on four separate notices, with Dirty Tommy's and the Garibaldi riff named repeatedly. **Liked with limits:** Saikyo Pasta, where ambience is the lowest score in the only rated review. **Too new to call:** the Choya bar, which has no independent review at all, and Après Gelato's September relaunch. **Nobody has called any of the four over-hyped**, and two of them have not been reviewed by anyone.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE HONEST METHOD NOTE

Four rooms that October round-ups filed as new were cut on their dates: one opened in May 2025, one in October 2025, one in May 2026, one in December 2025. A fifth was dropped because no second source could corroborate it existed. One date remains unresolved and is flagged rather than smoothed: Après Gelato is reported as opening on **3 April** by one outlet and as having "just opened" on **2 September** by another. **Burpple returned a 403, Time Out refused with a redirect, and Reddit refused for the eleventh issue**, so the four-out-of-five above was read through a search index. **One further opening was cut at the last moment: this magazine's own Table ledger bars a venue that ran only one issue ago, and it had.**[5]

UMESHU · TWELVE SEATS · KEONG SAIK · TOO NEW TO CALL

SOURCES 1 Launch coverage of the Choya Ginza Bar Singapore, 6 October 2026 onward; **at least one notice reads partly promotional, no independent review exists, and the brand's own Singapore page returns a 404; two outlets disagree on whether it opens on Sunday.** 2 HungryGoWhere, 17 June 2026, **on a hosted tasting**; The Ranting Panda, 8 September 2026, for the scores. 3 Boothby, 20 August 2026; Honeycombers and a listings magazine for the drinks and the rating. 4 Eatbook, 2 September 2026, and a lifestyle title of April 2026 for Après Gelato; **the two disagree on when it opened and no source bridges them.** 5 As stated in the boxes. **Every one of the ninety venues barred by this magazine's own Table ledger was checked against each candidate; twenty-six otherwise viable September and October openings were discarded for that reason alone, which is why this season's page leans to bars and counters rather than restaurants.**

LAND TENURE · PAPAKĀINGA ON WHENUA MĀORI

New Zealand freed papakāinga from planning law and left the title problem untouched

Regulations in force since 2 July permit ten homes per site with no resource consent, overriding all 65 district plans. In Tauranga, one of the country's fastest-growing cities, Māori land has yielded sixteen completed homes in five years.

The word is **papakāinga** — *papa*, the ground or foundation, and *kāinga*, the home or unfortified village. A clustered settlement built by a kin group on its own ancestral land, usually around a marae. For most of the last century it described a thing people remembered. Since 2 July 2026 it has described a class in New Zealand planning law, with its own national rulebook.[1]

The Resource Management (National Environmental Standards for Papakāinga) Regulations 2026 were made on 2 June and took effect a month later. They override every district plan in the country. On Māori ancestral land in Māori-purpose, residential and rural zones, **up to ten residential units per site are a permitted activity** — no resource consent at all, provided coverage and setback standards are met. Eleven to thirty units are restricted discretionary, with notification limited to iwi authorities, councils and immediate neighbours; above thirty, discretionary. A district plan may be more generous than the national standard; it may not be stricter.[2]

To see why this was worth doing, look at what it replaced. Te Puni Kōkiri reviewed all **65 district plans** in 2024 and found **twenty with no papakāinga rule at all**, and papakāinga permitted somewhere in only twenty-nine — so in thirty-six of sixty-five districts a family wanting to build on land it already owned needed consent everywhere. And much whenua Māori is rural, where, as the architect Jade Kake put it, district plans impose density provisions "of around one dwelling per 10 hectares". The bar was absolute.[3]

> ***New Zealand has given whānau permission to build on land that no one will lend against.***

So the reform is real, and it was overdue, and it is the wrong layer.[4]

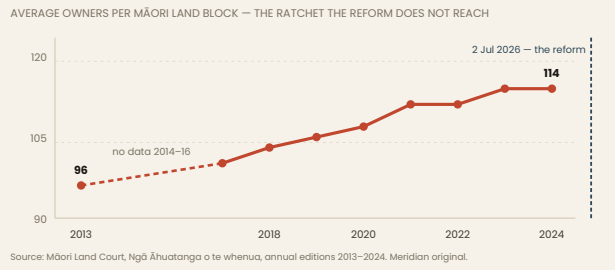
The binding constraint on building on Māori land is not zoning. It is title — a structure the Crown manufactured on purpose. The Native Lands Act 1865 created a court to convert customary communal tenure into individual freehold interests recognisable in English law, with a preamble that spoke of encouraging the extinction of native proprietary customs. Individualised shares then pass to heirs in equal undivided fractions, and are never consolidated. A hundred and sixty-one years later the Māori Land Court records **27,679 titles over 1,404,083 hectares**, carrying **3,287,810 ownership interests** — about **3.36 for every living person of Māori descent**.[5]

The average block runs to 53 hectares and **114 owners**. Sixteen thousand six hundred and eighteen blocks have no management structure at all; those average fifteen hectares and forty-five owners. No bank will take such a title as security, which is why the state's own lending product — the Kāinga Whenua loan — requires the house itself to be the collateral, and therefore requires the house to be removable. In practice that means **building on piles rather than a slab, at an extra forty to fifty thousand dollars a site**, and it means a licence to occupy, and a bank's ordinary income and credit test on top.[6]

SOURCES 1 The term's components are standard te reo Māori; the commencement date is confirmed three ways — a law firm's regulatory note of 16 July 2026, a district council's own implementation memorandum, and Te Puni Kōkiri's own release. 2 The regulations' operative provisions as set out in two independent New Zealand law firms' published analyses, which agree on content and date, and in the Te Puni Kōkiri consultation pack of 29 May 2025 for the coverage and setback standards. **legislation.govt.nz returned a 403 to every route attempted, and the Internet Archive refused as well, so the instrument itself was not read at source and the secondary readings are named.** 3 Te Puni Kōkiri, "Analysis of District Plan Papakāinga Rules", 22 May 2024, read at source; Jade Kake, then of the Auckland University of Technology, in a Science Media Centre expert reaction of 9 June 2025, read at source. 4 This magazine's argument, and the rest of this essay is the case for it. 5 The 1865 Act, the ten-owner rule and the preamble are **secondary, from a reference work**, because two New Zealand government history sites both returned 403s; if the point were load-bearing it would need a primary source, and the argument does not rest on it. The title and interest counts are from the Māori Land Court's own annual data update for June 2024, read in full as published; the per-person ratio is this desk's arithmetic against the 2023 census count of 978,246 people of Māori descent. 6 Same Land Court publication for the block averages and the no-structure count. **That document is internally inconsistent — its management-structure block counts and areas exceed its own title totals — so this essay uses its raw counts and its own stated percentages and derives no share-of-blocks figure.** The piles requirement and the forty-to-fifty-thousand estimate are from the Ministry of Housing and Urban Development's own release of the Kāinga Whenua loan review, read in full.

Sixteen. That is how many code compliance certificates Tauranga City Council issued for homes on Māori land in the five years to June 2026, in one of the fastest-growing cities in New Zealand, against thousands of homes built across the city in the same period. Sixteen. Hēmi Rolleston, the Te Awanui ward councillor, names the causes without flinching: Land Court process, multiple ownership, finance, infrastructure. At Matapihi, homes still cannot connect to the southern sewerage pipeline and run on septic tanks.[1]

Victoria Carroll, a papakāinga housing specialist who has spent her career on these projects, calls the figure **"a travesty"** and the process **"a nightmare"**, and then locates the gap exactly: **"The step that's missing is the project management element."** The council's answer is a **NZ$400,000 Papakāinga Fund**, raised from selling its elder-housing portfolio and aimed squarely at the costs that come before a builder arrives — planning, engineering, consenting. It expects to support up to five projects and about sixty homes. Rolleston's line on it is the one to keep: **"The greatest funding gap is often before construction begins."**[1]



The line is still rising, and the reform arrives to the right of the data. Owners per block, nine editions of the Land Court's own annual update; 2014 to 2016 are not published.[2]

Two things that Tauranga figure is not. It is one city's code compliance certificates rather than dwellings consented, and its denominator is published only as "thousands". It is an illustration, not a series — and the reason it has to carry the weight is that **no national count of completed papakāinga appears to exist**. The Crown reports approvals: NZ$426 million committed to Māori-led housing since December 2023, supporting about a thousand homes. Approvals are not roofs.[1]

And the ratchet does not stop. Across nine editions of the Land Court's own annual update, the average number of owners per block has risen in every published year: **96 in 2013, 103 in 2018, 107 in 2020, 111 in 2022, 114 in 2024**. An eighteen-point rise in eleven years, monotonic. Over the same period the land base *shrank* — 61,834 hectares gone, down 4.2 per cent — while the number of titles rose by 371. More titles, more owners in each, less land under them.[2]

This is where the comparison earns its keep, because another settler state did exactly the same thing and then spent real money undoing it. The United States General Allotment Act of 1887 divided tribal land into individual parcels for the same stated purpose — to make indigenous land alienable — and equal intestate succession did the rest. By 2009 the Interior Department recorded **143,663 individual allotments carrying more than four million fractionated interests**. Nobody could lease, mortgage or build without a coordination exercise nobody could fund.[3]

The parallel is exact in its mechanism and worth stating carefully. New Zealand's court was created in 1865 to convert customary communal tenure into individual freehold; the Dawes Act divided tribal land into parcels of forty to a hundred and sixty acres and sold the remainder. In both, intestate succession then multiplied the interests every generation, because each heir took an equal undivided share and nothing ever consolidated them. The result in both countries is land legally owned by so many people that it cannot be mortgaged, leased or built on without a coordination exercise nobody can fund. Both states also lost most of the land along the way: by 1939 Māori retained roughly one per cent of the South Island and nine per cent of the North.[3]

Then, under the Cobell settlement, the United States established a **US$1.9 billion Trust Land Consolidation Fund** and ran a Land Buy-Back Program from December 2012 to 24 November 2022, purchasing fractional interests from willing sellers and returning them to tribal communal ownership. It treated the title as the problem and bought the title back.[3]

SOURCES 1 Te Ao Māori News, "Only 16 Māori land homes in five years — Tauranga launches support fund", 29 June 2026, reported through Local Democracy Reporting and read at source, for the certificate count, the fund, the quoted councillor and specialist, and the Matapihi sewerage detail. **The sixteen is one city's code compliance certificates over five years and its denominator is given only as "thousands"; it is an illustration, not a national series, and no national count of completed papakāinga appears to exist.** 2 Māori Land Court, *Māori Land Update — Ngā Āhuatanga o te whenua*, nine annual editions from 2013 to 2024, each figure read in its own published PDF; **2014 to 2016 were not published and no 2025 or 2026 edition exists, so the chart plots nine discrete points and marks the gap rather than implying continuity.** Two adjacent series in the same documents — total ownership records, and owners per unmanaged block — contain evident methodology breaks and are deliberately not charted. 3 The **US$1.9 billion** fund, the December 2012 start and the 24 November 2022 close are confirmed at the Department of the Interior's own programme page; **the 143,663 allotments and four million interests are attributed to Interior's 2009 reporting through secondary accounts and were not read at source, and sources disagree on how the interests were counted.**

New Zealand has never attempted defractionation at any scale. It did the opposite: it layered *governance* over fractionated title so that someone could act for the owners without the shares ever being consolidated — **5,761 Ahu Whenua Trusts, 2,300 Māori Reservations, 146 Māori Incorporations**, plus more than twelve thousand Whānau Trusts. The new planning standard is the next layer on that stack: a zoning fix on top of a governance fix on top of an unfixed title. America spent nearly two billion dollars buying the shares back. New Zealand amended the zoning.[1]

America spent one point nine billion dollars buying the shares back. New Zealand amended the zoning.

The fairest objection is that this undersells the reform, and it has force. **Eighty-three per cent of the Māori land area is already vested in a management structure** — entities that can hold a licence to occupy, sign a contract and front a consent. For those blocks, averaging 113 hectares and 207 owners, planning really was the thing in the way, and it has really been removed. But that is also the distributional problem: the benefit lands on the land that was closest to being unlocked already, while the long tail of 16,618 blocks with no legal person to exercise the right gains a development right it cannot use.[1]

The second objection is that finance is being fixed in parallel. The loan cap has gone from two hundred thousand dollars to five hundred thousand a dwelling; **NZ$426 million** has been approved for Māori-led housing since December 2023, supporting about a thousand homes; a formal review of the loan is running. But read what that review's own hui concluded, in its own minutes: **"The wider system is a larger barrier to the success of the loan rather than the settings"**, and the product **"takes a western individual property rights arrangement and tries to apply it to multiply owned Māori land"**. That is a diagnosis of the mechanism, delivered to a review whose declared scope was adjusting the settings. The same minutes record that default risk on these loans is very low, especially to trusts — so the constraint is not credit risk. It is collateral law.[2]

The third objection is that nobody wants this. The demography answers it: **978,246 people of Māori descent, up 12.5 per cent since 2018, median age 27.2, with 29.1 per cent under fifteen** — a young population forming households now, of whom only about a third own, part-own or hold a home in a family trust. And the land is not merely unbuilt but underused: agricultural economists put **604,000 hectares of Māori freehold land and 229,480 hectares of settlement-entity land below ninety per cent of their regional productivity benchmarks**, with close to two billion dollars of annual output in that gap, against the 5.3 billion whenua Māori already generates in primary production.[3]

What makes this worth watching from eight thousand kilometres away is not the housing. It is the proposition being tested: that a state can deregulate its way out of a problem it legislated into existence. The planning layer was the one the Crown could remove with a stroke of a pen, so it removed that one, and the removal is genuine and will build genuine houses. The layer underneath is still compounding — ninety-six owners a block, then a hundred and fourteen — and nothing in the 2026 regulations touches it.[4]

The practitioners said so on the day. Kris MacDonald of Te Pouahi o Te Taitokerau, whose trust has consented more than eighty homes on whenua Māori, welcomed the reform and then qualified it in one sentence: **"We know from experience that planning reform alone does not build homes."** And Bill McKay of the University of Auckland, commending the proposal for what it gives back, noted the thing that brought this desk here — that it **"has received little publicity"**. A fortnight on, that is still true outside New Zealand.[5]

SOURCES 1 Governance-entity counts and the vested share from the Māori Land Court's own annual data update for June 2024, read in full; the eighty-three per cent is the document's own stated figure, not derived. 2 Ministry of Housing and Urban Development, official-information release on the Kāinga Whenua Loan Scheme Review, read in full, including the hui minutes quoted verbatim; the loan cap from Kāinga Ora's own page; the NZ$426 million and the thousand homes are the minister's own figures as reported, and are **approvals, not completions**. 3 Statistics New Zealand, "People of Māori descent living in Aotearoa New Zealand: 2023 Census", read at source; BERL for the Ministry for Primary Industries, "Whenua Māori in Primary Production", cover-dated October 2025, read in full. **The home-ownership share is for individuals aged fifteen and over and is not comparable with the national household rate; no like-for-like national individual figure could be verified, so none is set beside it.** 4 This magazine's argument. 5 Kris MacDonald in Te Ao Māori News, 7 June 2026, and Bill McKay in a Science Media Centre expert reaction, 9 June 2025, both read at source. **On the under-the-radar claim: five separate searches, two of which named the major Anglophone outlets explicitly, returned nothing from any of them — every result was New Zealand-domestic. Those outlets' own archives could not be searched directly, because all eight refuse this desk, so the claim is bounded by what open search shows. One further sceptical voice, a council hearing's concern that the provisions could be used by private developers rather than whānau, is left out because the council's site refused every route. The Ministry for the Environment's regulatory impact statement — which would carry the submission figures and any official estimate of homes enabled — refused this desk on every path, including the archive.**

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

The wrong layer

A thing worth noticing about repairs is how often they are made at the layer that is reachable rather than the layer that is broken. The United States Treasury cannot measure what a model can do, so this week it proposed deleting the measurement rather than improving it, and said so in its own preamble (p7). A four-hundred-and-twenty-eight-billion-parameter model shipped on Friday and wrote gibberish; every user suspected their own quantisation, and the fault was one layer down, in nine arguments a function never passed along (p8).

Europe once published a number that let you compare two vacuum cleaners. A court found the test unlawful because it was run with an empty bag, and the number vanished retroactively, as if it had never existed — so the category now has a floor and no ladder (p6). Twenty-four Dutch schools banned phones all day instead of only in lessons, and every wellbeing measure stayed exactly where it was; the only thing that moved was how connected the students felt to their teachers, downward (p13).

And on page twenty-five, a country repealed the planning rule that stopped Māori families building on their own land, which was a real obstacle and is really gone. Underneath it sits a title the same state manufactured in 1865: twenty-seven thousand titles carrying three and a quarter million ownership interests, an average of a hundred and fourteen owners a block, and the figure rising in every year anyone has published. America looked at the identical problem and spent one point nine billion dollars buying the shares back. New Zealand amended the zoning. The houses that get built will be real; so will the ones that do not.

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SOURCES **A note on method.** This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: a proposed rule in the Federal Register's own text endpoint; a company's own filing at the Securities and Exchange Commission; an issue and a merge request on a model runtime's own tracker; a central bank's price release, recomputed against the statistics department's own table; a European court's press summary and the Official Journal notice after it; a motor maker's bulletin from 1998; two headphone makers' and one watchmaker's specification pages; five papers read through the National Library of Medicine; a treasury's daily yield curve; a Japanese ministry's mineral-spring guideline and a city's own hot-spring data page; and nine annual editions of a land court's own statistical update. Three figures are this magazine's own arithmetic and all three say so (p21, p5, p6). Where a host refused us — **Reddit for the eleventh issue running; Reuters, the BBC and the Associated Press; every Miele and Dyson domain; VacuumLand, Head-Fi and Audio Science Review; Ticketmaster Singapore, SISTIC, Marina Bay Sands and Klook; the Land Transport Authority and Changi; New Zealand's own legislation site and the Internet Archive; and Wikimedia's image servers** — the page says so rather than quietly sourcing around it. **Gold on p14 is printed as a band because four venues could not be reconciled, and no air fare appears on p22 because none could be read at a carrier.**